

Drosophila ellipsoid body ring neurons instruct opposing internal states that remodel physiology and slow aging

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Abstract

Early studies of aging processes emphasized cell-autonomous mechanisms, but it is now well-established that some aspects of lifespan modulation are neurally mediated. Little is known, however, about the nature of the brain's involvement in aging or the mechanisms underlying these contributions. Understanding the neural regulation of aging has important implications for health, as it represents a theoretical upstream point of intervention in multiple aging processes. A neural locus shown to influence aging in multiple contexts would offer a promising proof of this concept. Our lab has identified one such locus in the ellipsoid body (EB), a neuropil in the *Drosophila* brain. The EB, whose diverse functions include behavioral and physiological regulation, sensory integration, and memory formation, is a component of the central complex (CX), a region functionally and structurally analogous to the mammalian basal ganglia (BG). We have found that manipulation of EB activity reverses the deleterious effects of multiple stressful environmental conditions and increases lifespan. Our data indicate that R2 and R4 ring neurons in the EB are particularly influential in modulating these phenotypes. We have discovered that direct manipulation of R2 and R4d neurons is sufficient to extend

lifespan, potentially via insulin-like signaling and other known aging pathways. These manipulations establish distinct metabolic and transcriptional profiles and are experienced with opposing valence, suggesting that differential circuit recruitment establishes distinct internal states. Whether these states engage distinct aging-related pathways or converge on shared peripheral mechanisms remains under investigation. We expect that a deeper understanding of how this neural integration center interfaces with conserved pathways will reveal broadly applicable principles underlying neural control of aging. Given the functional homology between the CX and mammalian BG, we expect these findings to provide a starting point for identifying similar mechanisms in mammalian brains.

Introduction

Over the past several decades, research across diverse model organisms, from yeast and nematodes to flies and mammals, has revealed that the rate of aging is not fixed and can be modulated by genetic, environmental, and pharmacological interventions (Gems and Partridge, 2013). Remarkably, many of the molecular pathways that regulate lifespan are highly conserved, suggesting that fundamental mechanisms of aging may be shared across taxa (López-Otín et al., 2013). While much of aging research has involved direct perturbation of these conserved pathways, an intriguing dimension of aging biology was revealed by the discovery that sensory perception can modulate lifespan independent of the physical activities associated with perceived stimuli (Pontillo and Lyu, 2025; Gendron et al., 2020; Miller et al., 2020; Garratt et al., 2022). Studies in the nematode worm, *Caenorhabditis elegans*, and the vinegar fly, *Drosophila melanogaster*, have demonstrated that sensory cues related to food, mates, and even the presence of dead conspecifics can initiate physiological changes that influence rates of aging (Gendron et al., 2014; Chakraborty et al., 2019; Libert et al., 2007; Hernandez-Lima et al., 2025; Miller et al., 2022). These effects are mediated by neuronal circuits that emanate from sensory tissues and interface with deeper regions of the central nervous system, ultimately engaging conserved neuromodulators, including biogenic amines and neuropeptides, that influence metabolism, stress resistance, and longevity (Chakraborty et al., 2019; Miller et al., 2020, 2022).

In certain instances, sensory perception has been shown to modulate lifespan through the motivational states that it influences. For example, the neuropeptide F system, homologous to mammalian neuropeptide Y, is a component of reward- and stress-related processing, and its activation can re-

50 duce starvation resistance and shorten lifespan (Ryvkin et al., 2024; Gendron et al., 2014). Sensory
 51 perception of potential mates shortens lifespan in male flies through circuits involving NPF signaling,
 52 whereas successful mating reverses these effects (Gendron et al., 2014), suggesting that an unresolved
 53 expectation of reward can influence lifespan. Insatiable hunger also slows aging, despite promoting
 54 behaviors normally associated with decreased lifespan (Weaver et al., 2023a). These observations in-
 55 dicate that identifying the neural circuits that interpret and integrate sensory inputs, as well as how
 56 they generate conserved internal states that prescribe physiological outcomes, may provide new insight
 57 into healthy aging.

58 In *Drosophila*, one neural substrate has recently emerged as a strong candidate for such an interpre-
 59 tive center: the ellipsoid body (EB). The EB resides within the central complex, a region that shares
 60 functional and organizational homology with the mammalian basal ganglia (Strausfeld and Hirth,
 61 2013). The EB is subdivided into concentric domains innervated by six major classes of ring neurons
 62 (termed "ER" neurons) that process visual, thermal, mechanosensory, and circadian information to
 63 drive behavioral outputs (Hulse et al., 2021; Buhl et al., 2021; Yan et al., 2023). Additional roles for
 64 EB ring neuron classes involve locomotor control, sleep, visual memory, and state-dependent action
 65 selection, suggesting that it is well-positioned to link myriad sensory representations to organismal
 66 state (Ofstad et al., 2011; Yan et al., 2023; Buhl et al., 2021; Kottler et al., 2019). Recent work
 67 has implicated this structure in aging biology. Exposure of flies to dead conspecifics, termed "death
 68 perception," reduces fat stores, lowers starvation resistance, and shortens lifespan in a manner that
 69 requires visual function and serotonin signaling through 5-HT_{2A}-expressing ER2 and ER4 neurons
 70 (Chakraborty et al., 2019). Insulin-like peptides, as well as the insulin-responsive transcription factor
 71 dFOXO, are required for aging effects of death perception, suggesting that EB ring neurons interface
 72 with conserved metabolic pathways implicated in lifespan control (Gendron et al., 2023).

73 The extent to which the results in *Drosophila* may illuminate similar processes in other taxa may
 74 hinge on the nature of the EB's role in influencing health-related outcomes. One possibility is that
 75 these neurons function primarily as passive conduits or gates for lifespan-altering sensory information:
 76 if their function is disrupted, flies may simply fail to perceive (Seelig and Jayaraman, 2013; Omoto et al.,
 77 2017) or internally represent salient stimuli, and phenotypes normally induced by those stimuli would
 78 not manifest. A more intriguing alternative is that the EB is an instructive modulator of aging-related

79 processes, and direct manipulation of ring neuron activity, independent of particular sensory input,
 80 would be sufficient to alter aging. If true, the EB and functionally similar structures—i.e., central
 81 hubs of neuromodulation and sensory integration—would serve as rich targets for aging research.

82 Here, we use a variety of optogenetic tools, which enable temporally precise activation or inhibition
 83 of genetically-defined neuronal populations, to show that *Drosophila* EB ring neuron populations are
 84 prescriptive modulators of aging that encode behaviorally meaningful information and orchestrate
 85 diverse transcriptional and metabolic responses throughout the animal. Activation of ER2 neurons,
 86 inhibition of ER4d neurons, and simultaneous activation of ER2 and ER4 neurons each extends lifespan
 87 in males and females, but the manipulations produce divergent transcriptional responses in head
 88 tissues, including distinct effects on insulin signaling, stress-response, and metabolic pathways. Despite
 89 these molecular differences, we detect no consistent changes in feeding, fat storage, or climbing ability
 90 that account for the longevity effects, arguing against a simple explanation based on overt energetic
 91 or behavioral shifts. Behavioral assays further show that ER2 activation alone produces a negatively-
 92 valenced state, whereas combined ER2/ER4 activation produces a positively-valenced state, indicating
 93 that distinct neural states with different immediate behavioral consequences can converge on increased
 94 lifespan. Transcriptomic and metabolomic profiling of peripheral tissues further reveals that ER2
 95 activation drives systemic metabolic remodeling, including suppression of proliferative programs and
 96 upregulation of electrochemical and membrane homeostasis pathways, demonstrating that EB ring
 97 neuron activity induces coordinated responses in the periphery. Together, these findings support a
 98 model in which the ellipsoid body serves as an integrative neural locus through which sensory and
 99 state-related processes act as active regulators of pro-longevity physiology via multiple downstream
 100 processes.

101 Results

102 Manipulating ER2 and ER4 neurons in the ellipsoid body extends fly lifes- 103 pan

104 To determine if the activity of ellipsoid body ring neurons is capable of modulating lifespan, we per-
 105 formed a series of experiments in which the activity of EB neurons was manipulated, with the following

considerations informing our experimental design. First, we sought to eliminate potential developmental effects and to restrict neuronal manipulations to adults with a developed central complex (Lovick et al., 2017). Second, we wanted to avoid tools that require introducing confounding factors, such as high temperatures, which can significantly affect lifespan and obscure treatment effects on aging (Miquel et al., 1976). Third, we wanted the flexibility to perform acute, cyclic, or chronic manipulations in ethologically-relevant contexts involving lifespan, behavior, and health assays. To accommodate these requirements, we adopted an optogenetic (Govorunova et al., 2015) approach to apply different treatment paradigms to freely-moving and fully developed adults by changing light-activation parameters and exposure times. To assay lifespans, we housed flies in custom optogenetic rigs with programmable, interchangeable LED bars, accommodating different channelrhodopsins and allowing us to either activate (Klapoetke et al., 2014) or inhibit (Mohammad et al., 2017) targeted neuron populations. Unless otherwise noted, flies in all treatment paradigms were exposed to light activation (40 Hz, 32% duty cycle) during ZT 0-12 of a 12:12 light:dark cycle, beginning at 3 days post-eclosion and continuing throughout adulthood, promoting a normal circadian rhythm and restricting neuronal manipulations to periods when flies would typically be alert and interacting with their environment (Fig. 1A). Flies were otherwise maintained using standard husbandry conditions (Linford et al., 2013).

We focused our investigation on ER2 and ER4, specifically ER4d, neurons, as these are required for the perception of dead conspecifics to modulate lifespan (Gendron et al., 2023) and for food perception to enhance starvation resistance (Luo et al., 2021). When flies expressing UAS-CsChrimson (Klapoetke et al., 2014) in ER2 neurons (ER2>Chr) were exposed to red light during subjective day, we observed a significantly extended lifespan in both females and males compared to siblings aged in the dark (Fig. 1B). This effect was not observed in genotype control flies that did not express CsChrimson, ruling out general lifespan-extending effects of red light and indicating a direct effect of neuronal activation. Activation of ER4d neurons had little meaningful effect on lifespan (Fig. S1A). However, when ER4d neurons were inhibited by exposing flies expressing the anion channelrhodopsin GtACR1 (Mohammad et al., 2017) to green light during subjective day, lifespan was significantly extended in both females and males (Fig. 1C). These results should be interpreted with caution, however, because we observed that exposure to high-intensity green light caused a significant reduction in lifespan in all cohorts (roughly 50% in females and 33% in males). Nevertheless, GtACR1 flies lived modestly but

135 significantly longer than control flies in the light, a pattern that was not observed in the dark.

136 The observation that ER2 and ER4d neuron activation had different effects on lifespan was some-
 137 what unexpected given that measures of ER2 and ER4 neuronal activity were both observed to
 138 be higher following exposure to dead conspecifics (Gendron et al., 2023), which accelerates aging
 139 (Chakraborty et al., 2019). We therefore decided to examine the effect of simultaneous activation
 140 of ER2 and ER4 (comprising ER4d and ER4m subpopulations) using a split-GAL4 driver. To our
 141 surprise, simultaneously activating both populations extended lifespan in males and females (Fig. 1D)
 142 to a greater extent than did ER2 activation alone. In this experiment, red light exposure modestly
 143 increased lifespan of CsChrimson-expressing flies as well as their genotypic controls, but the increase
 144 in lifespan was significantly greater in CsChrimson flies. Given the substantial increase in lifespan
 145 observed following simultaneous ER2/ER4 activation, we asked whether even broader manipulation of
 146 ellipsoid body neurons would recapitulate or even potentiate the lifespan extension that we observed
 147 following ER2 and ER2/ER4 neuron activation. Using a driver that targets additional EB neuron
 148 populations, including at least R3 neurons, we observed that broader EB inhibition had a modest
 149 effect on lifespan (Fig. 1E, left) and activation increased lifespan to an equal or lesser extent than ER2
 150 or ER2/ER4 activation alone (Fig. 1E, right).

151 Together, these data demonstrate that manipulation of ER2 and ER4 neural activity increases
 152 lifespan, supporting the notion that the ellipsoid body is an instructive modulator of aging. These
 153 results may be interpreted in the context of known activity patterns of ER2/ER4 in other contexts.
 154 Ishimoto et al. reported that ER2, ER4m, and ER4d neurons work together in an incoherent type
 155 1 feedforward loop (I1-FFL) (Ishimoto and Kamikouchi, 2020). Upon simultaneous activation of
 156 ER2/ER4m and ER4d, ER4d signaling initially increased, but sustained activity of GABAergic ER2
 157 and ER4m neurons gradually suppressed ER4d activity. If optogenetic activation recruits ER2/ER4 in
 158 this feedforward fashion, it may be that ER2 activation, ER2/ER4 activation, and ER4d inhibition are
 159 effectively the same intervention. Alternatively, they may engage partially or fully distinct pathways
 160 that converge on extended lifespan via different downstream mechanisms.

Different ring neuron manipulations produce distinct transcriptional profiles

To investigate how ER2 and ER4 neurons modulate aging and whether they do so via similar or distinct mechanisms, we performed bulk RNA-sequencing on brain-enriched tissues of female flies after one week of ER2 activation, ER4d inhibition, or ER2/ER4 activation, under the same conditions used in the lifespan assays described above. We chose to sample flies after one week of optogenetic manipulation to avoid survivorship bias that might arise at later time points while still allowing time for physiological differences to manifest. Flies were transferred directly from experimental rigs to liquid nitrogen, then decapitated by vortexing, and heads were collected with a sieve. Five biological replicates of 10 heads were collected for CsChrimson/GtACR1 and control genotypes from flies maintained either in constant darkness or channel-activating red/green lights during the 12 hours of subjective day. Whole head samples comprised primarily brain tissue, although other tissues were present, including the head fat body.

We used the DESeq2 package in R (Love et al., 2014) to identify transcriptional changes associated with enhanced ER2 neural activity. We specified a statistical model in which genotype (CsChrimson, control) and light stimulation (yes, no) served as main effects. A genotype $\times$ light interaction term was used to identify significant transcriptional changes that were specific to light-driven channelrhodopsin stimulation, and these were the primary focus of our analysis. After one week of ER2 neuron activation, we identified 123 genes (70 downregulated and 53 upregulated) whose expression values exhibited experiment-wise interaction p-values (corrected for false discovery rate) less than our cutoff of $p < 0.01$. Expression data from these genes produced clear separation of samples by treatment, indicating strong reproducibility across each of the five replicates (Fig. 2A). Hierarchical clustering revealed that samples from flies with activated ER2 neurons (i.e. ER2>CsChrimson flies exposed to red light) formed a distinct group from flies without neuronal activation, including CsChrimson-expressing flies maintained in constant darkness as well as control genotype samples maintained in either darkness or red light.

Despite a stringent threshold, we observed that one week of ER2 neuron activation drove broad but pathway-enriched changes in the head. Gene Ontology (GO) analysis of upregulated genes revealed enrichment for ribosome biogenesis and rRNA processing, insulin signaling, and response to starvation (Fig. 2B). Downregulated genes were enriched for protein folding and ER stress response pathways

(Fig. 2C). Together, these results suggest that activation of ER2 neurons induces a distinct metabolic state in the head, characterized by altered nutrient signaling and reduced ER stress. It also caught our attention that many of the differentially-expressed genes have been implicated in aging biology, with several known to modulate aging directly. For example, we observed the upregulation of multiple genes consistent with dampened insulin-like signaling (e.g., *foxo*, *Thor* (encoding d4E-BP), *InR*, *dilp6*) (Partridge et al., 2010); upregulation of autophagy-related genes such as *Atg101* (Guo et al., 2019); upregulation of *ImpL2*, an IIS antagonist which has been linked to lifespan extension (Alic et al., 2011); and higher levels of *Cbs*, which encodes the rate-limiting enzyme in the transsulfuration pathway and increases lifespan (Kabil et al., 2011). Together, these results demonstrate that short-term, part-time activation (12L/12D) of a few dozen ER2 neurons drives significant changes in multiple aging-, nutrient-, and stress-response pathways.

Following one week of ER4d silencing, far fewer changes in gene expression could be attributed to ER4d inhibition (Fig. 2D), although such changes were likely masked by remarkably potent independent effects of green light exposure. As observed for the ER2 data, sample-based clustering grouped biological replicates as more closely related to each other than to samples from all other treatments, demonstrating reproducibility. Consistent with its significant negative effect on lifespan (Fig. 1C), green light exposure affected the expression of 1,817 genes regardless of genotype (experiment-wise $p < 0.01$). However, only 11 genes (9 downregulated and 2 upregulated) were associated with a significant p -value for the genotype *times* light interaction term of the model, which indicates a differential response in flies with ER4d neurons silenced. Interestingly, in both genotypes, green light drove strong upregulation of multiple genes that encode heat shock proteins (e.g., *Hsp23*, *Hsp26*, *Hsp27*, *Hsp70Bb*), which was significantly muted in flies with ER4d neurons silenced. Other differentially-expressed genes following ER4d inhibition include the enzyme tyrosine hydroxylase (*ple*), which catalyzes the rate-determining step in dopamine synthesis (Neckameyer and White, 1993); the serine protease homolog *scarface* (Prasad and Hens, 2018); and several genes of unknown function.

We next asked how transcriptional changes following simultaneous activation of ER2 and ER4 compared to manipulations of the individual neuron populations. When ER2 and ER4 neurons were activated simultaneously, we once again observed high reproducibility with replicate samples within treatments being clustered together and flies with activated ER2/ER4 neurons forming a cluster dis-

219 tinct from both genotype and light controls (Fig. 3A). Using a false discovery rate-corrected cutoff
 220 of $p < 0.01$, we observed that ER2/ER4 activation resulted in roughly twice as many transcriptional
 221 changes as did ER2 activation alone (198 upregulated and 82 downregulated).

222 with additional enrichment of biosynthetic and glycogen-metabolism-related pathways A GO anal-
 223 ysis of the upregulated genes was dominated by metabolic pathways related to amino acid metabolism
 224 as well as pentose-phosphate- and NADPH-generating processes (Fig. 3B). We also observed an upreg-
 225 ulation of several known lifespan-modulating genes involved in one carbon metabolism, including *Cbs*,
 226 *Gnmt*, *Glyp*, *Glys*, *Nmdmc*, and *Zw*. Genes involved in starvation responses and lipid and carbohy-
 227 drate catabolism were significantly downregulated (Fig. 3C), which was in contrast to the upregulation
 228 of these pathways that we observed when ER2 neurons were activated alone. Notably, rather than
 229 recapitulating the effects of either of the previous two manipulations, or impacting a set of genes that
 230 was effectively a union of the two, the transcriptional profile of ER2/ER4-activated flies was distinct
 231 from those of both ER2 activation and ER4d inhibition, even where it impinged on similar pathways
 232 (Fig. 3D-E).

233 **EB ring neurons modulate nutrient-state signaling without corresponding** 234 **behavioral and physiological outputs**

235 Manipulations of ER2 and ER4d neurons alone and in combination produced markedly divergent tran-
 236 scriptional profiles in head tissues (Fig. 3C-D). This is at odds with a strict application of the I1-FFL
 237 circuit model (Ishimoto and Kamikouchi, 2020), which would predict that these three interventions
 238 ultimately converge on a common downstream state. Our data are instead consistent with function-
 239 ally distinct activity patterns across ER2 and ER4 populations encoding different interpretations of
 240 sensory stimuli or internal physiological signals, in keeping with the ellipsoid body's established role
 241 as an integrative center. If each manipulation imposes a distinguishable internal state, we reasoned
 242 that those differences might be reflected not only in gene expression but also in the behavioral or
 243 physiological programs those states normally coordinate. We therefore asked how ER2 activation,
 244 ER4d inhibition, and ER2/ER4 co-activation affected feeding, energy storage and mobilization, and
 245 organismal performance, phenotypes expected to track changes in nutrient state, motivational drive,
 246 and overall physiological condition.

Feeding behavior does not explain nutrient-state transcriptional signatures

Reduced nutrient intake, and homeostatic hunger drive *per se*, slow aging in *Drosophila* (Pletcher et al., 2002; Weaver et al., 2023a), and GO analyses of differentially-expressed genes in flies with activated ER2 and ER2/ER4 neurons identified pathways indicative of altered nutrient state and metabolism. We therefore asked whether the effects of neuronal activation might include changes in feeding that indicate a hunger state or that underlie the observed transcriptional differences. To assay for feeding changes, we measured the volume of food intake using a consumption-excretion (“con-ex”) assay (Shell et al., 2018). Flies were placed on food containing a blue dye tracer for 24 hours under the same light regime used for lifespan assays, after which we quantified the amount of dye deposited on vial walls. Because flies can behaviorally and physiologically adapt to chronic neuron manipulation (Weaver et al., 2023a), we tested light-naïve flies as well as flies that had been pre-treated with light for one week or one month, to evaluate changes over a significant portion of the lifespan.

We found no clear evidence that activation of ER2 neurons alone or ER2/ER4 neurons in combination produces consistent changes in food consumption. Except for males of advanced age, ER2 neuron activation resulted in no significant effects on feeding. Naïve male and female ER2>Chr flies excreted amounts of blue dye statistically indistinguishable from genetic controls (Fig. 4A, left panels for each sex). After one week of light pre-treatment, individuals from the same cohort of flies were randomly distributed among new vials and tested again (Fig. 4A, center panels). We again observed no light-driven changes in feeding by ER2>Chr males or females. Following a month of light pre-treatment, males, but not females, exhibited a significant reduction of feeding, as evidenced by a statistically significant interaction effect (Fig. 4A, right). There were also no consistent effects of ER2/ER4 neuron activation on feeding. The interaction term was not statistically significant for males or females that were light-naïve (Fig. 4B, left panels for each sex) or given one week (Fig. 4B, center) or one month (Fig. 4B, right) of pre-treatment. We observed a nominally significant increase in ER2/ER4-activated female feeding after one week ($p = 0.041$), but this effect did not survive correction for multiple comparisons. These results suggest that ER2 and ER2/ER4 activation do not robustly regulate feeding.

273 **Lipid stores and starvation resistance do not correlate with transcriptional signatures of** 274 **ER2 and ER2/ER4 activation**

275 If the starvation-like transcriptional signature induced by ER2 activation reflects a true nutrient-
 276 deprived physiological state, we might expect flies to exhibit hallmarks of nutrient deprivation, in-
 277 cluding reduced triglyceride (TAG) stores as well as altered starvation resistance and activity levels.
 278 After one week of ER2 activation to match RNA-seq treatment, TAG levels were unchanged in females
 279 but significantly reduced in males (Fig. 4C), whereas ER2/ER4 activation significantly reduced TAG
 280 in both sexes (Fig. 4D), contrary to the observed decrease in starvation-response genes. We then
 281 examined if TAG differences predicted survival under nutrient deprivation. Flies of both sexes were
 282 pre-treated with light for one week to match TAG assay conditions before being flipped onto 2%
 283 agar, a hydrating but non-nutritive medium. Females of both genotypes were more sensitive to starva-
 284 tion than controls (Fig. 4E-F, left panels). In males, starvation outcomes diverged despite overlapping
 285 effects on TAG: ER2>Chr males were only modestly sensitized to starvation compared to their dark
 286 controls, an effect driven by a long tail in control survival. By contrast, ER2/ER4d>Chr males were
 287 significantly sensitized (Fig. 4E-F, right panels). That starvation sensitivity was not associated with
 288 reduced TAG was especially notable in ER2>Chr females, in which longevity extension and starvation-
 289 associated transcriptional signatures occurred without detectable TAG depletion; nevertheless, they
 290 were accompanied by reduced starvation resistance. Together, these findings indicate that EB neuron
 291 activation can alter lipid storage and starvation survival in ways not explained by food intake and not
 292 simply predicted by inferred nutrient state, suggesting that neural activation influences nutrient-state
 293 signaling independent of canonical metabolic and physiological outputs.

294 **Negative geotaxis reveals delayed, sex-specific effects of ring neuron manip-** 295 **ulation**

296 Ring neurons have established roles in locomotor control (Buhl et al., 2021; Kottler et al., 2019), so we
 297 next asked whether an evoked motor assay might reveal differences among neural manipulations that
 298 measures of baseline feeding, TAG storage, and starvation resistance did not. To assess this, we tested
 299 negative geotaxis, a stereotyped climbing response widely used to measure age-sensitive locomotor
 300 performance and neuromuscular function in *Drosophila* (Rhodenizer et al., 2008; Jones et al., 2009).

Flies were assayed using our custom “D-Drop” platform, which drops a chamber containing multiple single-fly lanes and uses video tracking to quantify several characteristics of flies’ subsequent climbing behavior. To gauge climbing speed and overall robustness, we focused on maximum height reached 9 sec after drop and total upward distance climbed over 30 sec. Light-naïve flies were omitted, as flies were not optogenetically stimulated during this assay. ER2>Chr flies of neither sex exhibited a significant genotype $\times$ light interaction for either metric after one week or one month of activation (Fig. 5A). ER2/ER4d activation likewise produced no detectable effect after one week of pre-treatment in either sex (Fig. 5B, left panel for each sex). After one month of pre-treatment, however, female ER2/ER4d>Chr flies outperformed controls in both height at 9 sec and total upward distance (Fig. 5B). Males showed a modest decrease in climbing ability (Total Up $p = 0.045$), but this effect did not survive multiple testing correction.

We observed that green light *per se* shortens lifespan (Fig. 1C) and causes molecular stress responses (Fig. 2D) in both control and GtACR1 flies, and that ER4d neuron inhibition may buffer these stress responses. We therefore asked if the effects of green light stress manifest physically as reduced negative geotaxis and if ER4d inhibition would promote endurance against this purported stress. In females, we saw a modest trend toward reduced climbing ability after one week of ER4d inhibition (Total Up $p = 0.035$); however, after multiple testing correction, there were no detectable effects at either time point (Fig. 5C). In males, by contrast, ER4d inhibition improved both climbing metrics after one week pre-treatment, and this advantage persisted after five weeks of pre-treatment. ER4d activation, by comparison, produced only nominally significant improvements in climbing in either sex prior to correction (Total Up female $p = 0.040$, male $p = 0.046$) (Fig. S2A).

Overall, negative geotaxis did not clearly resolve the functional differences between ER2 and ER2/ER4 manipulations. No effects were evident at the one-week time point corresponding to our transcriptional analysis, indicating that the early molecular states induced by these perturbations are not accompanied by parallel changes in evoked climbing behavior. Divergent effects emerged only later in ER2/ER4 females, but whether these represent delayed consequences of the earlier transcriptional programs remains unclear. By contrast, ER4d inhibition produced a robust and sustained improvement in male climbing performance. Because comparable transcriptomic data are not available for males, we cannot determine whether this sex-specific phenotype reflects a shared molecular program

with different behavioral output or a distinct underlying mechanism. Though TAG levels and starvation resistance were decreased in some conditions, our ring neuron manipulations did not otherwise significantly alter baseline behavioral patterns or produce gross nutritional or performance deficits. Transcriptional patterns characterized by GO do not map onto predictable, detectable differences in these common health and behavior readouts, suggesting that lifespan extension is not a secondary consequence of changes in these phenotypes.

ER2, ER4d, and ER2/ER4 activation produce distinct valence states

Our results suggested that EB ring neurons act instructively, imposing distinct internal states whose immediate consequences are separable but whose downstream effects converge on lifespan regulation. In natural environments, ring neuron activity is engaged by behaviorally relevant stimuli, including cues that drive discrimination of nutritive value (Park et al., 2016) or avoidance of threatening conditions (Buhl et al., 2021). Because standard husbandry conditions are relatively benign and homogeneous, however, the motivational consequences of experimentally imposed EB states may be muted under baseline conditions. We therefore next asked whether these manipulations differ in valence, reasoning that their attractive or aversive properties might clarify the functional logic by which EB circuits influence lifespan.

We first measured valence using the FLIC assay, which permits flies to associate optogenetic stimulation with self-initiated interactions with liquid food at a defined well (Ro et al., 2014). In this paradigm, individual flies were presented with a choice between a water well and a 10% sucrose well, and closed-loop optogenetic stimulation (red light for CsChrimson or green light for GtACR1) was triggered selectively by contact with the sucrose food. Each “trigger” fly was paired with a yoked control that received identical light stimulation determined solely by the behavior of the trigger fly, without relationship to its own feeding behavior (Fig. 6A). This design allowed us to ask whether activation or inhibition of specific EB neuron populations altered the perceived reward value of the sucrose-associated food while accounting for non-associative consequences of light exposure (increased hunger, for example). As with our behavioral assays, we performed these experiments both in light-naïve flies and in flies pre-exposed to light for one week or one month. Because FLIC data can be used to extract several features of feeding behavior, it allowed us to assess the valence of each ma-

nipulation using multiple behavioral dimensions. Each FLIC signal over threshold was scored as an “interaction” with the liquid food, and these data were further parsed into the number of discrete well visits (“events”) and the duration of those visits (“median duration”) (Weaver et al., 2023b). Increased sucrose interactions, more frequent visits, or longer visit durations were interpreted as evidence of positive valence, whereas rapid abandonment of the trigger well or subsequent avoidance was taken to indicate negative valence. Due to the sophistication and limited throughput of this assay, and because our transcriptomic analyses were performed in females, we restricted this component of our study to females to enable direct comparison between observed valence and underlying transcriptional states.

Again, we first tested ER2 activation, prompted by the observation that ER2>Chr animals exhibited transcriptomic signatures consistent with nutrient stress and starvation-like state changes. If so, we reasoned that activation of ER2 neurons might be negatively valenced or might alter the motivational salience of a nutritive stimulus, respectively. Indeed, light-naïve ER2>Chr trigger flies showed a marked reduction in interactions with the sucrose well relative to yoked controls, indicating that contact with the trigger well was strongly aversive despite the inherent attractiveness of sucrose (Fig. 6B, left). This effect was accompanied by a significant reduction in event duration (Fig. S2A, left), suggesting that flies rapidly disengaged from the well once stimulation was triggered. Notably, however, ER2>Chr flies did not reduce the number of visits to the sucrose well, implying that ER2 activation did not simply condition avoidance of the well itself (Fig. S2A, right). Instead, these data suggest a more acute aversive state that promotes premature disengagement while leaving repeated approach behavior largely intact. This trend remained evident after one week (Fig. 6B; $p = 0.035$ uncorrected) and one month (Fig. 6B, right) of light pre-treatment, indicating that the negative valence associated with ER2 activation does not substantially diminish with chronic exposure.

Because the transcriptional profile induced by ER2 activation was associated with genes involved in starvation response, we considered whether the aversive effect of ER2 stimulation might obscure a parallel increase in motivation to feed. In principle, if ER2 activation enhanced food drive while simultaneously imposing negative valence, then the immediate aversive response of trigger flies could preclude increased sucrose consumption. To test this possibility, we modified the yoked design to include a single, wild-type trigger fly and two yoked animals, one ER2>Chr and one genetic control (Fig. S2B, left). Under this configuration, both yoked animals experienced light delivery uncoupled

387 from the food and at a frequency determined by normal feeding of the wild-type trigger fly. If ER2
 388 neuron activation increased hunger, we would expect the yoked ER2>Chr flies to approach or interact
 389 with the sucrose well more often than yoked control animals. Despite equivalent stimulation, however,
 390 yoked ER2>Chr flies did not show increased sucrose consumption relative to yoked controls (Fig. S2B,
 391 right), arguing against the idea that ER2 activation induces a hunger phenotype, which is consistent
 392 with our feeding data described above.

393 We next sought to evaluate the behavioral consequences of ER4d inhibition. Interpretation of
 394 these experiments, however, was again complicated by the green light required for GtACR1 activation.
 395 In our assay conditions, abrupt green-light delivery appeared to be intrinsically aversive or startling,
 396 producing reduced interactions and shorter event durations in both ER4d>GtACR1 flies and genetic
 397 controls. Although trigger flies expressing GtACR1 in ER4d neurons displayed aversion to the sucrose
 398 well, a similar response was observed in trigger flies of the control genotype, precluding a clear assign-
 399 ment of valence to ER4d inhibition itself (Fig. S2C). Thus, under these conditions, the FLIC assay
 400 could not distinguish the effects of ER4d inhibition from the effects of light exposure.

401 Given these limitations, we instead used activation as an alternative means of probing the behavioral
 402 state associated with this population. In light-naïve flies, ER4d activation produced a behavioral
 403 signature resembling that of ER2 activation: trigger flies had fewer interactions with the sucrose well
 404 (Fig. 6C, left; uncorrected $p = 0.05$), made shorter visits (Fig. S2D, left), and showed no reduction in
 405 the number of visits (Fig. S2D, right). Thus, as with ER2 stimulation, ER4d activation appeared to
 406 promote rapid disengagement from the trigger well rather than suppressing repeated approach to the
 407 sucrose source itself. This aversive effect persisted after one week of pre-treatment (Fig. 6C, center)
 408 but was no longer evident after one month of chronic light exposure (Fig. 6C, right) suggesting that,
 409 unlike the response to ER2 activation, the negative valence associated with ER4d activation attenuates
 410 over time.

411 We next asked how flies respond when ER2 and ER4 neurons are activated simultaneously. Based
 412 on the aversive effects of activating either ER2 or ER4d alone, one might expect combined activation
 413 to produce a similar or even stronger negative response. Instead, ER2/ER4 activation in light-naïve
 414 flies increased the number of interactions with the sucrose well (Fig. 6D, left; uncorrected $p = 0.020$).
 415 Although median visit duration was unchanged (Fig. S2E, left), the frequency of visits increased

(Fig. S2E, right), indicating that stimulation reinforced engagement with the trigger-associated food source. ER2/ER4-activated trigger flies continued to interact more with the sucrose well than their yoked controls after one week and one month of pre-treatment; however, at these later time points, there was no longer a significant (at $p < 0.05$) genotype $\times$ light effect (Fig. 6D, center and right, respectively), perhaps due to an increase in among-fly variance. Nevertheless, ER2/ER4 flies showed a trend toward greater attraction to the well than controls at these later time points ($p = 0.06$ – 0.1).

Together, these data indicate that simultaneous activation of ER2 and ER4 neurons produces a state consistent with positive valence, in contrast to the aversive effects observed when either population is activated alone.

EB valence is shaped by context, sex, and circuit composition

To test whether the valence effects observed in the FLIC generalized beyond a feeding context, we assayed place preference in a rectangular multi-lane arena in which one half of each lane was illuminated and the other remained dark. Unlike the closed-loop FLIC, this open-loop design delivered light on a pre-programmed schedule regardless of fly position, dissociating valence from sucrose contact or response-contingent stimulation. Flies were observed during a 10-min dark acclimation period followed by a 60-min light treatment period of 5 sec on/5 sec off. Light-naïve flies of both sexes were tested, and each manipulation was evaluated at two stimulation frequencies (48 Hz to mimic FLIC conditions, and 200 Hz) to further gauge generalizability.

The positive valence of ER2/ER4 co-activation generalized cleanly. Both sexes significantly preferred the illuminated side during treatment, and it was observed at both 48 Hz (Fig. 7B) and 200 Hz (Fig. S3A), indicating that the appetitive state reflects a stable property of the ER2/ER4-activated circuit rather than an artifact of a particular assay or stimulation regime.

Consistent with the FLIC results, activation of ER2 neurons in females produced a clear avoidance of the illuminated side during the treatment period (Fig. 7C, left), indicating that the negative valence associated with ER2 activation extends beyond feeding-related behavior. This effect was also observed under a higher-frequency stimulation regime, supporting the robustness of the phenotype across light conditions (Fig. S3B, left). In males, ER2 activation produced the opposite preference: males preferred the illuminated side during both treatment and recovery at 48 Hz (Fig. 7C, right), with a weaker effect

at 200 Hz (Fig. S3B, right). Thus, the arena revealed a sex-dependent valence for ER2 activation.

By contrast, the FLIC findings for ER4d manipulation did not generalize robustly. ER4d>GtACR1 and control flies showed indistinguishable side biases (females preferring illumination, males avoiding it; Fig. S3D), so although the open-loop design removed the light-startle confound, it did not permit an unambiguous valence assignment. ER4d activation, which had been aversive for naïve flies in the FLIC, produced variable behavior in the arena: females showed little avoidance at 48 Hz but avoided illumination at 200 Hz (Fig. 7D, left; Fig. S3D, left), while males avoided illumination at 48 Hz but showed no preference at 200 Hz (Fig. 7D, right; Fig. S3D, right). The absence of a stable signature across conditions suggests that ER4d neurons act in a more context-sensitive or modulatory fashion than ER2 or ER2/ER4.

In summary, the behavioral consequences of EB manipulation are nonlinear and depend on circuit composition, sex, and assay context. ER2/ER4 co-activation produced a robust positive valence that generalized across sex and assay paradigms, whereas ER2 and ER4d manipulations did not yield consistently generalizable valence signatures. Together, these findings argue that EB ring neurons do not make fixed, additive contributions to motivational state, but instead generate qualitatively distinct and differentially stable internal states through combinatorial recruitment, raising the question of how such state differences relate to the common downstream outcome of extended lifespan.

ER2 neuron activation remodels metabolism in peripheral tissues

Finally, to examine how EB neuron manipulation in the brain influences gene expression and physiology in the periphery, we performed bulk RNA-sequencing and metabolomic profiling on headless bodies of female flies. We focused on ER2-activated flies to determine whether the strong starvation-response program observed in heads would manifest in the periphery. Body donors were reared and collected the same way as head donors. Bodies were separated from heads using a sieve, and five bodies were collected for each of five samples. Again, using DESeq2 to identify genes with a significant genotype (CsChrimson, control) *times* light (yes, no) interaction, we identified 229 upregulated and 181 downregulated genes in peripheral tissues (experiment-wise p-value < 0.01) (Fig. S4A). Strikingly, the peripheral transcriptional response was nearly completely distinct from that observed in the head, with only 7 of 526 differentially-expressed genes shared between compartments (Fig. 8A), indicating

472 that ER2 activation drove tissue-specific transcriptional programs.

473 Despite the disparity in response genes, downregulated processes were consistent with the starvation-
 474 like transcriptional profile in heads, as ER2 activation drove peripheral downregulation of genes in-
 475 volved in cell cycle progression and DNA synthesis and repair (Fig. 8B). These included replication
 476 factors *PolA2*, *Cdc45*, and the Cdt1 ortholog *dup* (Whittaker et al., 2000); mitotic regulators *Cdk1*, *twe*
 477 (*Cdc25*), and *fzy* (*Cdc20*); kinetochore and centrosome components *Mis12*, *Sas-4* (CENPJ), and *spd-2*
 478 (*Cep192*); and DNA repair factors *RecQ5*, *Mlh1*, and *Pms2*. Chromatin remodeling and transcriptional
 479 factors were likewise downregulated, indicating a shift away from proliferative states.

480 By contrast, we did not observe an upregulation of canonical stress- or starvation-response genes in
 481 bodies. Instead, the peripheral response was characterized by electrochemical homeostasis and organel-
 482 lar acidification (Fig. 8C). Among the most significantly upregulated genes were more than a dozen
 483 vacuolar H⁺-ATPase subunits and accessory factors, including *Vha16-1*, *Vha68-2*, *Vha44*, *VhaAC45*,
 484 *VhaSFD*, *Vha26*, *VhaAC39-1*, *Vha55*, *Vha100-2*, and *ATP6AP2*. This V-ATPase program was not
 485 accompanied by the upregulation of autophagy or trafficking pathways. We also noted the upregula-
 486 tion of three inwardly rectifying potassium channels (*Irk1*, *Irk2*, and *Irk3*), as well as an enrichment of
 487 lipid-associated processes, including genes involved in fatty acid synthesis (*ACC*) and ether phospho-
 488 lipid synthesis (*Agps*). Notably, we also observed inductions of *Sam-S* and *Gnmt*, indicating changes
 489 in methionine flux.

490 Targeted metabolomic profiling of peripheral tissues using a similar experimental design, but a less
 491 restrictive experiment-wise $p < 0.05$ cutoff, revealed a broad and coordinated metabolic remodeling
 492 that reinforced our interpretation of the transcriptional response. PCA revealed that the single most
 493 influential source of variance in the data was neuronal activation, as PC1 (accounting for 41.2% of the
 494 variance) separated ER2>Chr flies exposed to light from all other samples (Fig. 9A). A total of 87
 495 metabolite abundances were found to be significantly affected by ER2 neuron activation (Fig. 9B-C).
 496 Among the 47 metabolites reduced in abundance, the dominant pattern was broad depletion of free
 497 nucleotides and nucleosides, including purines, pyrimidines, and modified nucleoside species, along-
 498 side a broad reduction in free amino acids and derivatives. Reductions in S-adenosylhomocysteine
 499 (SAH), choline, glycerophosphocholine, and acylcarnitines were also observed. Three biochemical
 500 modules emerged from the 40 significantly upregulated metabolites: a central carbon module com-

prising glycolytic and TCA-cycle intermediates including pyruvate, oxaloacetate, and cis-aconitate alongside pentose phosphate pathway species; a small nitrogen species module containing glutamine, arginine, serine, and betaine; and a tryptophan-kynurenine module marked by coordinated elevation of kynurenic acid, quinolinic acid, and anthranilic acid. Pathway-level analysis using FELLA, which maps metabolite changes onto the KEGG network to identify enriched biological modules, corroborated these findings and indicated additional enrichment of taurine and hypotaurine metabolism, beta-alanine metabolism, and folate transport, with starch and sucrose metabolism and nucleotide sugar biosynthesis also represented (Fig. 9D).

Discussion

Here, we show that direct activation of ER2 neurons, co-activation of ER2/ER4 neurons, and inhibition of ER4d neurons are each sufficient to promote longevity in adult flies of both sexes. These effects are elicited by manipulating very small neuronal populations—in some cases, fewer than ten neurons per hemisphere (Omoto et al., 2018)—underscoring the sensitivity of organismal aging to defined circuit states. Our findings establish that the EB can act instructively to modulate aging rather than serving only as a permissive gate for lifespan-altering sensory information. Previous work showed that ER2 neurons are required for death perception to accelerate aging (Gendron et al., 2023) and, notably, that constitutive activation of ER2/ER4 neurons using heat-gated TRPA1 modestly reduced lifespan (Gendron et al., 2023). Read together with the data reported here, these contrasting outcomes suggest that the timing and persistence of EB activity help define ER-neuron-dependent neural states and their effects on aging, consistent with the context-sensitivity of valence that we observed.

We also find that manipulations of different EB populations likely modulate aging through distinct molecular mechanisms. Bulk head transcriptomics after one week of treatment revealed that ER2 activation, ER4d inhibition, and ER2/ER4 co-activation produced largely non-overlapping transcriptional programs. The differences were not merely quantitative: where the manipulations converged on shared pathways, they often did so in opposite directions, with starvation- and catabolism-related genes upregulated by ER2 activation but downregulated by ER2/ER4 co-activation. Rather than resolving immediately to a common state, then, distinct activity patterns across ER2 and ER4 populations appear to be proximally interpreted as distinct internal states that each extend lifespan.

Our experiments also revealed, perhaps fortuitously, that ER4d inhibition may enhance the ability to buffer moderate stress. Green light alone shortened lifespan and broadly induced heat-shock proteins (e.g., *Hsp23*, *Hsp26*, *Hsp27*, *Hsp70Bb*) in both control flies and flies expressing GtACR1. ER4d silencing produced few genotype-specific changes apart from significantly attenuating this stress signature. Because temperatures in our ventilated rigs were not meaningfully elevated above those of dark-aged controls, heat is unlikely to explain these effects. Fly vision is more sensitive to green than to red light (Salcedo et al., 1999), and certain wavelengths can exert physical effects on the brain (Song et al., 2022) and shorten lifespan (Johnson et al., 2023); the intensity and duration of exposure required for deep brain penetration in our experiments (Wolff et al., 2015) likely rendered green light a meaningful stressor. Whether the attenuated molecular response in ER4d-silenced flies actively contributed to their longer lifespan, or instead reflects a reduced stress burden, remains to be determined, as does whether a comparable mechanism operates under more benign conditions.

The transcriptional data also point to specific pathways that may link EB activity to aging-regulatory physiology. Following ER2 activation, the induction of *foxo*, *Thor*, *InR*, *dilp6*, and *Cbs* suggests a coordinated engagement of nutrient-sensing, proteostatic, and sulfur-amino-acid metabolic processes previously implicated in lifespan control. This state does not, however, resemble a canonical starvation program: nutrient-responsive IIS components were induced alongside ribosome biogenesis and translational programs that are not ordinarily co-regulated in this way (Essers et al., 2016), suggesting that direct EB activation may uncouple pathways normally coordinated by nutrient availability. Because prior work showed that ER2/ER4 neurons regulate *dilp3* and *dilp5* expression in insulin-producing cells during death perception (Gendron et al., 2023), one plausible hypothesis is that EB-dependent internal states are translated into systemic aging effects through downstream neuroendocrine centers, though the present data do not establish this mechanism directly, and defining the relevant effector pathways will require future work.

The internal states established by EB manipulation were molecularly specific yet were not accompanied by the behavioral or physiological changes those states would ordinarily predict. GO analysis revealed opposite transcriptional indicators of nutrient availability in the head: starvation-response processes were upregulated by ER2 activation (Fig. 2B) but downregulated by ER2/ER4 activation, which instead enriched for biosynthetic and storage-associated processes including amino acid syn-

thesis and glycogen metabolism (Fig. 3C), suggestive of a nutrient-replete state. Neither signature was matched by a change in feeding. The ER2 signature could have reflected reduced intake or a hunger-like state that should itself promote feeding, yet we observed neither; the nutrient-replete-like ER2/ER4 signature was likewise unaccompanied by any feeding change. These transcriptional states therefore arise directly from neural activation rather than secondarily from altered consumption, and they argue against dietary restriction as the basis of lifespan extension. The same dissociation extended to other coarse phenotypes: despite unchanged feeding, TAG stores were reduced in ER2 males and in both sexes after ER2/ER4 activation, yet these changes tracked neither lifespan extension nor starvation resistance, and negative geotaxis revealed no early correlate of the one-week transcriptional states. Together, these results indicate that EB-dependent regulation of aging is not readily explained by gross changes in feeding, lipid storage, or locomotor performance.

The absence of feeding and physiological correlates did not, however, mean that EB manipulation was motivationally silent; each manipulation instead imposed a distinct, dissociable motivational state. In the FLIC assay, ER2 activation in females was aversive, promoting rapid disengagement from the sucrose well without suppressing re-approach, whereas ER2/ER4 co-activation was positively valenced, increasing both the number of interactions and the frequency of return without prolonging individual feeding bouts. In a feeding-independent place-preference assay, the positive valence of ER2/ER4 co-activation generalized across sex and stimulation regime, whereas the aversive states were more context dependent: the negative valence of ER2 activation was restricted to females but held across light regimes, while that of ER4d activation generalized across sex but only appeared under different stimulation regimes. Together, these findings indicate that EB ring neurons do not contribute fixed, additive aversive or appetitive signals; rather, the motivational meaning of EB activity depends on population combination, assay context, sex, and stimulation conditions.

A particularly informative consequence of this combinatorial structure is that manipulations of opposite valence both extend lifespan: ER2 activation, which was aversive in females, and ER2/ER4 co-activation, which was appetitive, each reliably increased survival in males and females. This is difficult to reconcile with models in which longevity is mediated by a particular motivational valence, or by any single downstream behavioral or physiological state that valence would normally engage. It is also difficult to reconcile with a strict reading of the incoherent feedforward circuit in which

ER2, ER4m, and ER4d neurons are thought to participate (Ishimoto and Kamikouchi, 2020), under which ER2 activation, ER2/ER4 co-activation, and ER4d inhibition should converge on a common downstream state. This model is at odds with the divergence we observed in transcriptional profile, valence, and downstream physiology, although we cannot exclude convergence on a shared terminal mechanism farther downstream of the EB. A more parsimonious interpretation is that EB circuits influence aging through population-level configurations whose downstream consequences depend on the particular combination of neurons engaged, consistent with the EB's established role as an integrative rather than relay structure. In this view, lifespan extension is not the signature of a single privileged EB activity pattern but a property of multiple distinguishable circuit states, each recruiting partially distinct downstream programs that nonetheless converge on slower aging, with the transcriptional divergence we observed implying distinct molecular routes to a shared outcome.

Molecular profiling of peripheral tissues revealed that ER2 activation drove coordinated systemic remodeling beyond the brain. In bodies, ER2 activation suppressed proliferative and DNA repair programs while upregulating a vacuolar H^+ -ATPase-dominated electrochemical homeostasis program not observed in heads, indicating tissue-specific rather than uniform physiological responses. That this V-ATPase program was not accompanied by autophagy or trafficking pathways suggests a decoupling of organellar acidification from degradative and secretory functions. The accompanying upregulation of inwardly rectifying potassium channels may help maintain cell membrane potential during increased organellar proton flux, while the enrichment of fatty acid and ether phospholipid synthesis genes suggests a remodeling of cellular and organellar membranes to support increased ion transport.

Metabolomic profiling reinforced this interpretation. The depletion of free nucleotides and amino acids likely reflects the reduced proliferative burden evident in our transcriptional data, while reductions in choline, glycerophosphocholine, and acylcarnitines may reflect increased membrane remodeling activity. Among upregulated metabolites, the accumulation of glycolytic and TCA-cycle intermediates, together with glutamine and arginine, is consistent with reduced consumption of these species by growth-related processes. Serine and betaine serve as methyl donors, and their elevation, alongside depletions in SAH and choline and the upregulation of both *Sam-S* and *Gnmt* in head and body, indicates a restructuring of methionine cycle flux. Although none of the core kynurenine pathway genes were upregulated in our RNA-seq dataset, the coordinated elevation of kynurenic acid, quino-

linic acid, and anthranilic acid could account for the depleted tryptophan signature. The convergence of transcriptomic and metabolomic data indicates that activation of the small population of ER2 neurons imposes an orchestrated, tissue-specific remodeling of peripheral physiology that is distinct from canonical starvation or dietary restriction.

Our finding that discrete or combined populations of ellipsoid body ring neurons can instructively modulate lifespan by generating distinct internal states carries potentially significant implications for understanding the neural basis of aging in humans. The *Drosophila* central complex, of which the ellipsoid body is a core component, shares strong neuroanatomical and functional homology with the vertebrate basal ganglia (Strausfeld and Hirth, 2013). Both structures serve as integrative hubs that process sensory information, coordinate motor output, and critically contribute to the generation of motivational and affective states. In particular, limbic basal ganglia output pathways, including ventral pallidal circuits, can assign appetitive or aversive value to ongoing behavior and reshape responses to challenge in a state-dependent manner (Stephenson-Jones et al., 2020). Our findings raise the possibility that a similarly general principle applies to aging: circuit configurations that impose distinct motivational or physiological states may converge on long-term effects on organismal maintenance and survival. More generally, these results suggest that lifespan may be modulated not only by what animals perceive, but by how neural state transforms the meaning of those perceptions into coordinated physiological output. If analogous circuits in the human brain similarly encode valence states that influence systemic physiology, this would provide a mechanistic framework for understanding associations between psychological states, chronic stress, and aging in humans.

Materials and Methods

Fly stocks and husbandry

Eggs were collected from grape juice agar as described in Gendron et al., 2023, and 32 μ L of eggs were aliquoted into bottles containing 25-50 mL of CT larval growth medium (recipe?). Channelrhodopsin-expressing flies and their genetic controls were reared and maintained in dim 12:12 light:dark conditions at 25° C and 60% humidity. Unless otherwise specified, flies were collected 0-1 days after eclosion, transferred to 10% sucrose/10% yeast (SY10) medium, and allowed to mate for 2-6 days. Mated

flies were then sorted by sex onto all-trans retinal (500 μ M ATR) SY10 medium, 20/vial, under brief CO₂ anesthesia. Adult flies were flipped onto fresh food every 2-3 days until completion of experiments. Dark controls were flipped in a dark room to minimize incidental channel activation. The following stocks were used, and obtained from the Bloomington Drosophila Stock Center: white Canton-S (WCS), UAS-CsChrimson (BDSC #55315), UAS-GtACR1 (BDSC #92983), UAS-20X-GFP (BDSC #32194), ER2-GAL4 (BDSC #48343), ER4d-GAL4 (BDSC #48487), ER2/ER4-GAL4 (BDSC #75997), and BDSC #39805 (broader EB).

Optogenetic assays

After being sorted onto ATR food, flies were placed in a dark box for at least 1 day to allow enough time for all-trans retinal uptake before light stimulus. Flies used for lifespan assays or 1-week or 1-month assay time points were then transferred to optogenetic rigs. Dark controls remained in a dark box in the same incubator. Light-naïve flies for behavioral assays were maintained for 1 week in the dark box to age-match 1-week light-treated flies. Our optogenetic rigs house 48 vials between 2 LED light bars, and rig walls are mirrored to facilitate consistent light distribution across vials. Rigs and behavioral assay equipment use 627 nm (red) or 530 nm (green) Luxeon LEDs. Control boards allow the experimenter to set light intensity, duration, and other stimulus parameters. Vial position was randomized within each optogenetic rig and dark box.

Lifespan assays

Each treatment comprised 5-10 vials of 20 flies each (see Fig. 1 caption for populations per experiment). Flies were 3-9 days old when entering light; experimental and control genotypes were age-matched **to within a day**. Flies were exposed to 12 V (red) or 20 V (green) light from ZT 0-12 every day (40 Hz, 32% duty cycle). Rigs and dark boxes were maintained in incubators set to 25° C and 60% humidity. **Male R2 was a different program than everything else; rheostat paper doesn't specify program, so do we just omit that generally?**

667 **Starvation assays**

668 Flies were 3-4 days old when placed into light for 1 week of pre-treatment before starvation assays.
 669 After pre-treatment, flies were removed from ATR medium, sorted into 10 vials of 10 flies, and placed
 670 onto 2% agar, which provides water but not nutrition. Anti-fungal agent Tegosept was omitted from
 671 starvation medium to avoid introducing a nutritive solvent (EtOH). Flies were treated with red light
 672 for the duration of the assay and flipped onto clean agar every 2-3 days. Surviving flies were counted
 673 every few hours. Counting frequency increased as experiment progressed, as starving vials often go
 674 extinct within a short window. Due to the high frequency of census taking, starvation flies were not
 675 kept in an incubator, but at room temperature (21.1-23.3° C) and ambient humidity.

676 **Survivorship analysis**

677 For lifespan and starvation survival analysis, we performed pairwise comparisons of dark and light-
 678 treated survivorship curves using the DLife software (Linford et al., 2013) and R. P-values were ob-
 679 tained by log-rank analysis of color-coordinated pairs in Fig. 1 and Fig. 4.

680 **Brain dissections**

681 These 3 sections are adapted from the rheostat paper. Changed language but it might be too close.
 682 Driver (GAL4) lines were crossed with UAS-20X-GFP. Adult female brains were dissected in phosphate
 683 buffer saline (PBS) and fixed for an hour at room temperature in PBS containing 4% paraformalde-
 684 hyde. Brains from ER2, ER2/ER4, and BDSC #39805 drivers were transferred to a glass slide with
 685 Vectashield mounting medium (ZH0219), sealed with a coverslip and nail polish, and immediately im-
 686 aged. Because ER4d comprises relatively few neurons, ER4d>20X-GFP brains were immunostained
 687 for GFP before being similarly mounted for imaging.

688 **Immunostaining**

689 ER4d-GFP brains were transferred to a microcentrifuge tube and quickly washed 3 times with 1 mL
 690 of PBS with 0.1% Triton-X (PBS-T). Brains were then given 3 longer 1 mL PBS-T washes, with
 691 tubes placed on a low-speed orbital shaker at room temperature for 20 min for each wash. PBS-T was

692 removed, blocking solution was added (5% normal goat serum), and tubes were returned to the orbital
 693 shaker for 30 min at room temperature.

694 Blocking solution was removed and a 1:500 dilution of rabbit anti-GFP (Sigma-Aldrich SAB4301138)
 695 in 5% normal goat serum was added. Tubes were placed on an orbital shaker at 4° C for 2 days. On
 696 day 3, the anti-GFP solution was removed and brains were given 3 quick and 3 long PBS-T washes as
 697 described above. PBS-T was removed and a 1:1000 dilution of anti-rabbit Alexa Fluor 488 (Invitrogen
 698 A-11008) in 5% normal goat serum was added. Tubes were covered in foil and placed on an orbital
 699 shaker at 4° C overnight, after which the secondary antibody was removed and brains were given 3
 700 quick and 3 long PBS-T washes. Brains were then mounted for imaging as described above.

701 **Imaging and analysis**

702 An Olympus FLUOVIEW FV3000 confocal microscope was used to image brains for Fig 1. Images
 703 were acquired with a 20× (0.75 NA) objective lens at 1024 × 1024 pixels with a step size of 3.0
 704 μm. Imaging files were analyzed using Fiji. Selective slices were combined using SUM projection.
 705 Brightness and contrast were adjusted similarly across treatments for visualization purposes.

706 **Consumption-excretion assay**

707 Con-ex experiments were performed as previously described (Shell et al., 2018), with the addition of
 708 ATR (250 μM final) to the dyed food (FD&C Blue No. 1). Light-naïve flies were sorted 10/vial instead
 709 of 20/vial for overnight ATR pre-treatment, to allow for direct flipping into con-ex vials without
 710 anesthesia the following day. From an initial cohort of 120 flies, 100 were chosen for each time point
 711 (10 vials). The remainder were treated identically to the analyzed experimental flies (including during
 712 assays) and were maintained to compensate for possible age-related attrition at later time points.
 713 Flies were 3-4 days old for the first (light-naïve) timepoint, to match standard lifespan conditions.
 714 After 24 hours, dyed food caps were removed, and flies were returned to standard ATR SY10 medium
 715 (20/vial) and placed back in the light rig or the dark box. Dye deposited on walls was washed by
 716 vortexing 3 mL of DI water in each vial. Absorbance was measured as described by Shell et al., 2018.
 717 For subsequent time points, remaining flies were re-mixed on a cold pad, and 100 per condition were
 718 selected for analysis as above. 1-week time points were performed after 7 days in light (i.e. 6 days

after end of naïve time point). Male ER2/ER4 1-month time point was performed after 34 days in light; all others were performed after 28 days in light. Blue excrement did not persist until subsequent time points. Vials in which one or more flies died or became stuck during the assay were excluded from analysis.

TAG assay

Three- to 5-day old flies were placed in red light rig or dark box for 1 week, then frozen at -80° C. Flies were homogenized in groups of 10 (except for ER2/ER4 females, which were in groups of 5) in 150 μ L PBS with 0.05% Triton X. TAG was measured using the Infinity Triglyceride reagent (Thermo Electron Corp.) Ten biological replicates were analyzed.

Negative geotaxis assay

Negative geotaxis was assayed using equipment and tracking software developed by our lab (D-Drop Deluxe and DTrack). Flies were maintained as in lifespans (12 V red light or 19.5-20 V green light) and given 1 week (6-8 days) or 1 month (21-34 days) of light treatment starting at 3-8 days of age, after 2-5 days of mating. D-Drop does not have integrated optogenetic LEDs, making this the only behavioral assay without concurrent neuron activation/inhibition (therefore no naïve time point was included). For assay, flies were anesthetized on a cold pad and individually transferred into lanes of custom 12-lane or 14-lane chambers, then placed at 25° C in ambient light or in a dark box for 10-25 minutes to recover. Chambers were then loaded onto the "D-Drop Deluxe," an instrument that drops, illuminates, and records videos of single chambers. Each chamber was dropped 3 consecutive times and recorded for 30 sec after each drop. After recording, flies were given an additional 30 sec to recover (60 total sec between drops). Light-treated flies were dropped under ambient light conditions, with a ring light (for recording) contributing additional light. Dark controls, though kept light-naïve until the assay, were also subjected to this ring light during recording. Height reached by 9 sec after drop and total up distance climbed in 30 sec after drop were averaged across replicates. Interaction (Light $\times$ Genotype) p-values were derived from 2-way ANOVAs. Benjamini-Hochberg FDR correction was applied within each sex and driver and across time points and climbing metrics. [Get hardware details from Scott](#)

Fly liquid-food interaction assay

Flies were assayed by the Fly Liquid-food Interaction Counter (FLIC) developed by our lab (Ro et al., 2014).

Two-choice FLIC *Drosophila* Feeding Monitors (DFMs, Sable Systems International, model DFMV3) were used, with one well containing 10% sucrose (w/v) in DI water and the other containing DI water alone. Each DFM contained 6 chambers, and genotypes were mixed within DFMs, although 2- or 3-way yoked pairing was maintained across neighboring chambers. Flies were anesthetized on a cold pad, aspirated into chambers, and given a few minutes to recover before recording began. Interactions were recorded for 6 hours between ZT 3 and 11 to avoid crepuscular feeding peaks. DFMs were staged in enclosed environments maintained at 25° C.

Flies started light treatment (or aging in dark box) at 3-7 days post-eclosion. Light-naïve flies were aged for 7-12 days in dark before assays. One-week time points were pre-treated for at least 7 and up to 14 days. One-month time points were pre-treated for 28-29 days.

Data were pooled from three replicates and analyzed using R code developed in-house: https://github.com/PletcherLab/FLIC_R_Code (minimum feeding threshold = 10, event gap = 5, tasting threshold = (0, 10)). `code version? RR_ whatever` Adapting Kristy's methods, not sure what tasting threshold is; maybe relevant to Kristy and not me?) Flies with no feeding signal, or whose baseline signal was unstable, were omitted from analysis. If a "trigger" fly engaged in 0 sucrose well interactions, both it and its yoked control were omitted from analysis. Sucrose interaction p-values were derived from the Genotype $\times$ Linkage (where Linkage = trigger fly or yoked control) interaction term of a linear mixed model (Interactions = Genotype * Linkage + (1|Group), lmer) with yoked pairs modeled as a random intercept. Events and median durations were analyzed similarly. Benjamini-Hochberg FDR correction was applied within each sex and driver and across interaction time points.

light parameters? same as arena?

Place preference assay

Seven- to 21-day old light-naïve flies were aspirated into individual lanes of a multi-lane rectangular arena ((Fig. 7A). Flies were given 10 minutes to acclimate to the arena in the dark, after which one half of the transparent arena floor was illuminated for 60 min (5 sec on/5 sec off). GtACR1 flies and

774 their genetic controls were exposed to green light at 24 V/40 Hz/32% duty cycle. CsChrimson flies
 775 and their genetic controls were exposed to red light (18 V) at either 48 Hz/32% duty cycle (meant to
 776 mimic FLIC light parameters) or 200 Hz/20% duty cycle. Control and experimental genotypes were
 777 alternated between lanes. Illuminated side of the arena was varied between runs. Data were pooled
 778 across 2-3 runs. probably need some hardware/software info from Scott.

779 RNA sequencing data acquisition

780 For bulk head and body transcriptomics, 3- to 6-day old female flies were placed into optogenetic
 781 rigs or maintained in the dark in the same incubator for 1 week, after which they were flash-frozen
 782 in liquid nitrogen. The same light parameters were used as for lifespans above. Flies were combined
 783 within conditions and vortexed to remove heads from bodies. Heads and bodies were sorted using a
 784 sieve, counted on dry ice in a petri dish, and placed into chilled bead lysis tubes. Ten heads or 5
 785 bodies (ER2 only) were grouped per sample, and 5 samples were sequenced per condition. (Should I
 786 mention that the bodies are a separate batch?) RNA was extracted using the New England BioLabs
 787 Inc. (NEB) Monarch Total RNA Miniprep Kit (T2010S). Samples were lysed in 800 μ L of the kit's
 788 lysis buffer at 6.5 m/s for 15 seconds in a FastPrep-24 homogenizer (MP Biomedicals). Bulk RNA
 789 was extracted according to manufacturer's instructions (including the optional DNase treatment) and
 790 sent to Admera Health LLC for library preparation using polyA selection and the NEBNext Ultra II
 791 Directional RNA Library Prep Kit. Libraries were sequenced on an Illumina platform with 2 $\times$ 150 bp
 792 paired-end reads at a depth of 40 M reads per sample (20 M per direction). (Check files from Admera
 793 to see how they performed alignment and QC? Big Data server)

794 RNA sequencing data processing and statistical analysis

795 Raw sequencing counts were analyzed using the DESeq2 package (v. 1.48) in R (Love et al., 2014). We
 796 used a 2 $\times$ 2 factorial design with Treatment (Light vs. Dark) and Genotype (Experimental vs. Control)
 797 as factors, modeling gene expression as `Treatment + Genotype + Treatment:Genotype`. Dark and
 798 Control were used as reference levels. We pre-filtered for genes with counts ≥ 10 in at least 3 samples.
 799 Differential expression was assessed using DESeq2's default Wald test with Benjamini-Hochberg FDR
 800 correction. Genes with $\text{padj} < 0.01$ were considered differentially expressed.

Heatmaps of log2-transformed normalized counts of differentially expressed genes were generated using the pheatmap R package (v 1.0) (Kolde, 2025), with hierarchical clustering (Euclidean distance, complete linkage) and row-wise z-score scaling.

Gene Ontology (GO) enrichment analysis was performed using the clusterProfiler package (v. 4.16) in R (Xu et al., 2024). Differentially expressed genes ($\text{padj} < 0.01$) were separated into upregulated and downregulated sets and tested independently for enrichment of Biological Process terms, using the pre-filtered gene set as the background universe. Enrichment significance was assessed with a Benjamini-Hochberg FDR adjusted p-value cutoff of 0.05 and a q-value cutoff of 0.2. Redundant GO terms were collapsed using clusterProfiler's simplify function with a semantic similarity cutoff of 0.7. Rather than retaining the most statistically significant term in each cluster, we retained the most specific term, defined as the term with the greatest number of ancestors in the GO Biological Process hierarchy.

Metabolomics data acquisition, processing, and statistical analysis

Three-day-old female flies were treated and harvested as described for RNA sequencing. Six samples of 30 whole female bodies were sent to the University of Washington's metabolomics core for analysis.

Got this from Christi; if we keep it I'll modify the wording a bit, but I don't have a similar level of detail for RNA-seq. *Preparation of biological tissue samples for targeted LC-MS without absolute concentration: Adapted from Daniel Djukovic and Lisa Bettcher* 10 mg of body tissue samples were homogenized in 200 μL of cold (4°C) Milli-Q water with zirconium oxide beads using a Bullet Blender. After homogenization, metabolites were extracted by adding 800 μL of methanol containing internal standards. This extraction solution was prepared by spiking 100 mL of methanol and 1 mL of 12.370 mM ^{13}C -Glucose and 0.4 mL of 6.463 mM ^{13}C -glutamic acid. The mixture was vortexed for 10 seconds, incubated at -20°C for 30 minutes, then sonicated in an ice bath for 10 minutes. To separate the extracts, the mixture was centrifuged at 14K RPM for 15 minutes at 4°C . A 600 μL aliquot of the supernatant was transferred to a new tube, and the samples were dried completely in a Speedvac at 30°C for approximately 2 hours. The dried pellets were then stored at -80°C until the reconstitution step. The dried pellets were then reconstituted in 1,000 μL of a hydrophilic interaction liquid chromatography

(HILIC) solvent. The HILIC solvent was made by a 30:70 mixture of mobile phase solvents A1 (10 mM ammonium acetate in 95% H₂O/3% acetonitrile/2% methanol + 0.2% acetic acid) and B1 (10 mM ammonium acetate in 93% acetonitrile/5% water/2% methanol + 0.2% acetic acid), and was spiked with internal standard to a final concentration of 19.58% μ M ¹³C-lactate and 3.550 μ M ¹³C-tyrosine. The reconstituted samples were vortexed for 10 seconds and centrifuged for 5 minutes at 14K RPM in 4° C. The final aliquot of the supernatant was transferred to LC vials for mass spectrometry.

Targeted (specifics?) metabolomics data from bodies were analyzed using a 2×2 factorial design with Treatment (Light vs. Dark) and Genotype (ER2>Chr vs. ER2>WCS) as factors. Metabolites with more than two missing values across all samples were removed. Remaining abundances were natural log-transformed and mean-centered per sample. Residual missing values were imputed using KNN imputation (k = 5). A separate OLS linear regression ($y = \text{Treatment} \times \text{Genotype}$) was fit to each metabolite, with Dark and ER2>WCS as reference levels. Benjamini-Hochberg FDR correction was applied independently to each coefficient family (Treatment, Genotype, and interaction). Metabolites with an interaction FDR < 0.05 were considered significant. Pathway enrichment was performed using the FELLA package in R, which leverages the topological structure of the KEGG metabolic network. The KEGG database for *Drosophila melanogaster* (organism code: dme) was compiled using buildGraphFromKEGGREST, excluding global overview pathways (map01100). Enrichment was conducted using the diffusion method, with the background defined as all metabolites in the input matrix with valid KEGG compound identifiers. Pathway nodes with a diffusion p-score < 0.10 were considered enriched.

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1011 **Figures**

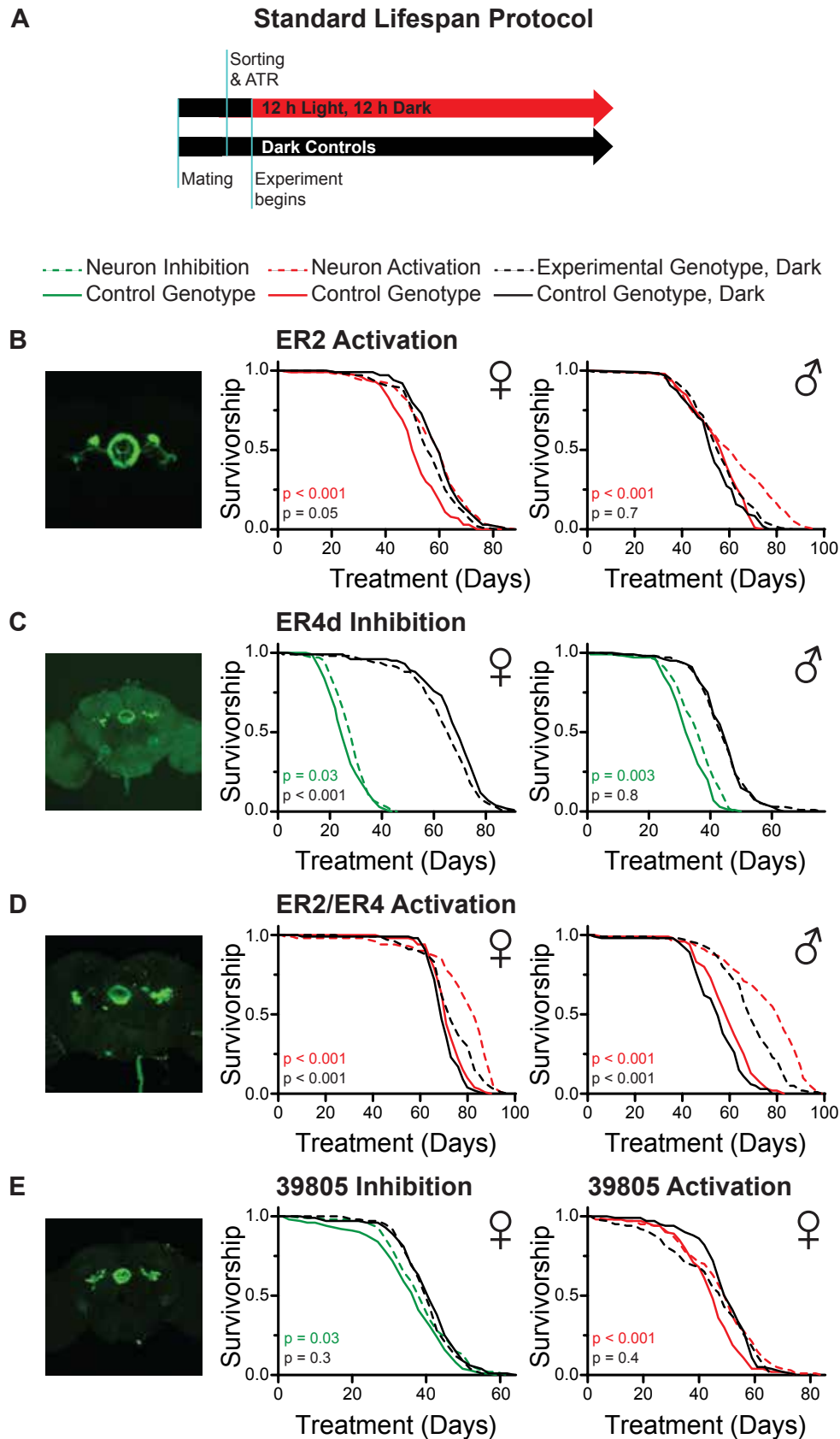


Figure 1. Manipulation of ellipsoid body neurons ER2 and ER4 extends lifespan in female and male flies. (A) Flies were mated for two days, then separated by sex and sorted 20/vial onto all-trans retinal food for 24 hours before optogenetic treatment began. (B–D) (Left) Expression patterns of drivers used in each experiment. Neurons were either activated (dashed red lines) using UAS-CsChrimson, or inhibited (dashed green lines) using UAS-GtACR1. Dark controls (black lines) were included for all experiments. P-values were obtained by log-rank analysis of correspondingly colored lines. Control genotypes (solid lines) were bred by crossing respective GAL4 drivers with WCS. (B) Activation of ER2 extended lifespan in both sexes. n = 95-117. (C) Inhibition of ER4d extended lifespan in both sexes. n = 145-189. (D) Simultaneous activation of ER2 and ER4 neurons extends lifespan in both sexes. n = 127-139. (E) Inhibition (left) and activation (right) of broader EB (BDSC 39805) extends lifespan in females. GtACR1 n = 127-133; Chr n = 95-115. (B–E) P-values were obtained by log-rank analysis of line pairs indicated by color.

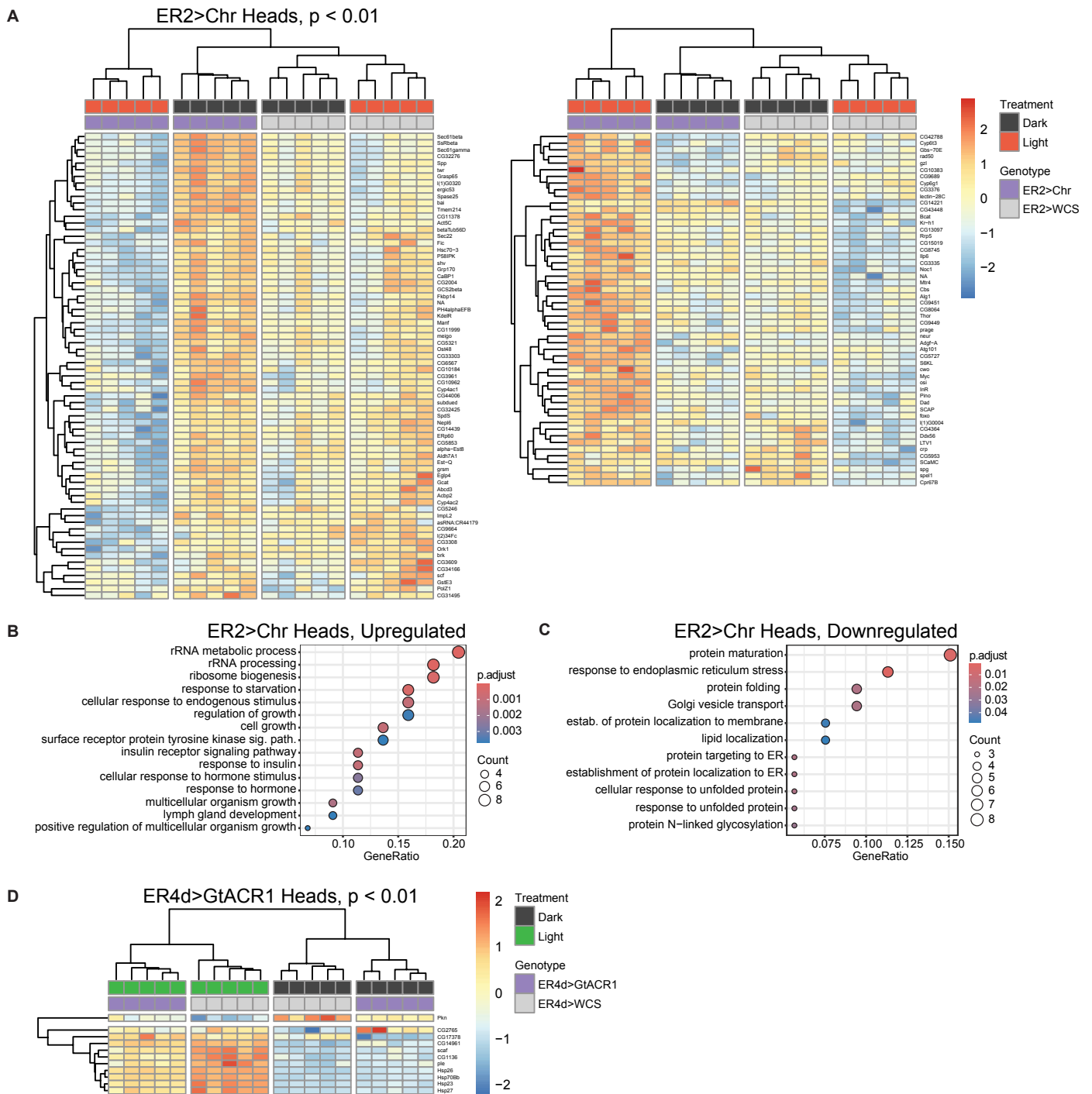


Figure 2. ER2 activation drives broad transcriptional changes and produces a head transcriptomic profile distinct from ER4d inhibition. Bulk RNA-seq data from whole heads of female flies treated with light for 1 week shows broad transcriptomic changes in R2>Chr flies. Ten heads were collected per sample. Differentially expressed genes (DEGs) identified at FDR < 0.01 (Benjamini-Hochberg correction) using DESeq2 R package. **(A)** DEGs downregulated (left) and upregulated (right) by ER2 activation (ER2>Chr). **(B)** Top 15 GO Biological Processes upregulated by ER2 activation. **(C)** Top 11 GO Biological Processes downregulated by ER2 activation. **(D)** DEGs driven by ER4d inhibition (ER4d>GtACR1).

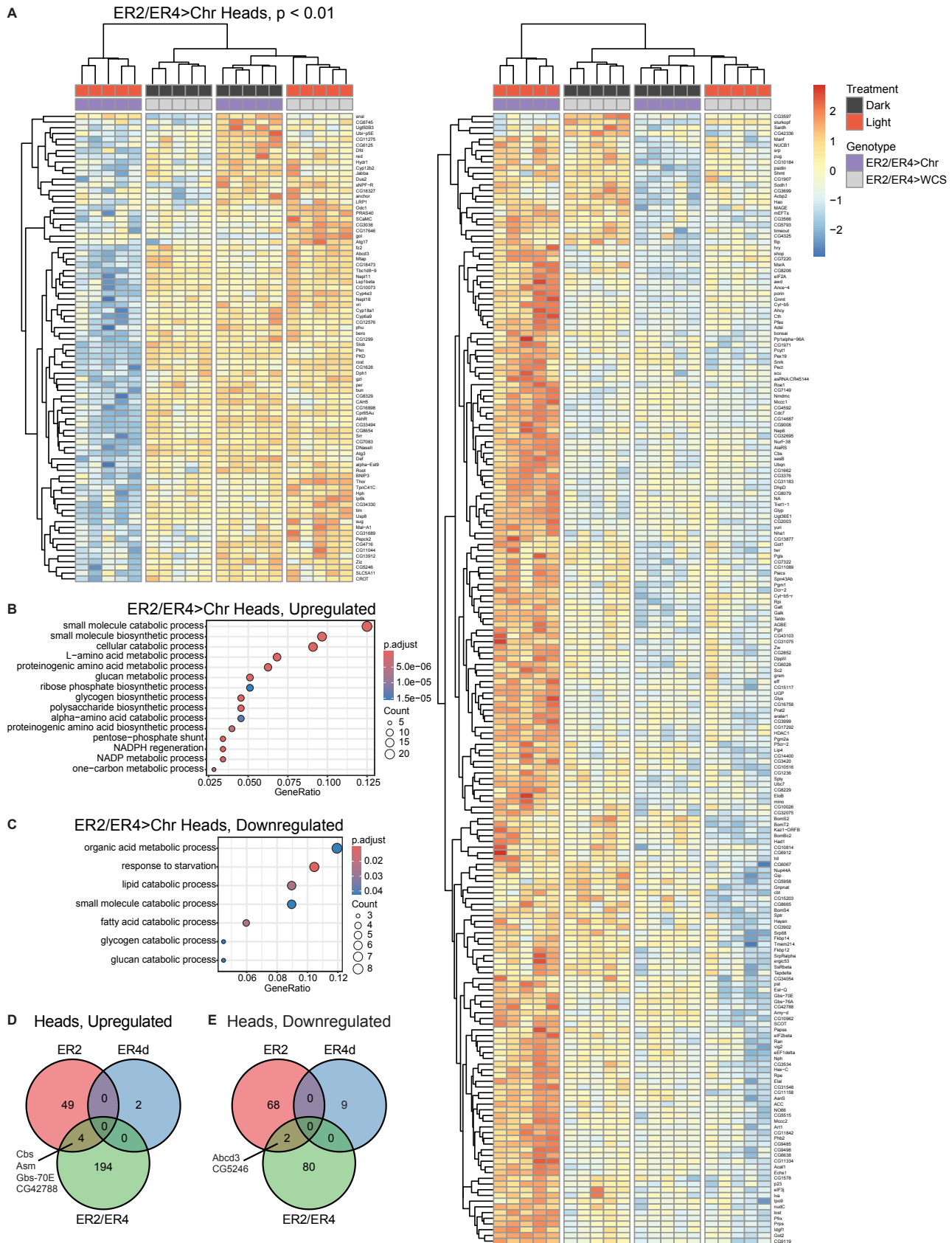


Figure 3. ER2/ER4 activation shares little transcriptomic overlap with ER2 activation or ER4d inhibition. Bulk RNA-seq data from whole heads of female flies treated with light for 1 week. Ten heads were collected per sample. Heatmap shows differentially expressed genes (DEGs) identified at FDR < 0.01 (Benjamini-Hochberg correction) using DESeq2 R package. **(A)** DEGs downregulated (left) and upregulated (right) by ER2/ER4 activation (ER2/ER4>Chr). **(B)** Top 15 GO Biological Processes upregulated by ER2/ER4 activation. **(C)** Top 7 GO Biological Processes downregulated by ER2/ER4 activation. **(D)** Overlap between upregulated head genes in all 3 manipulations. **(E)** Overlap between downregulated head genes in all 3 manipulations.

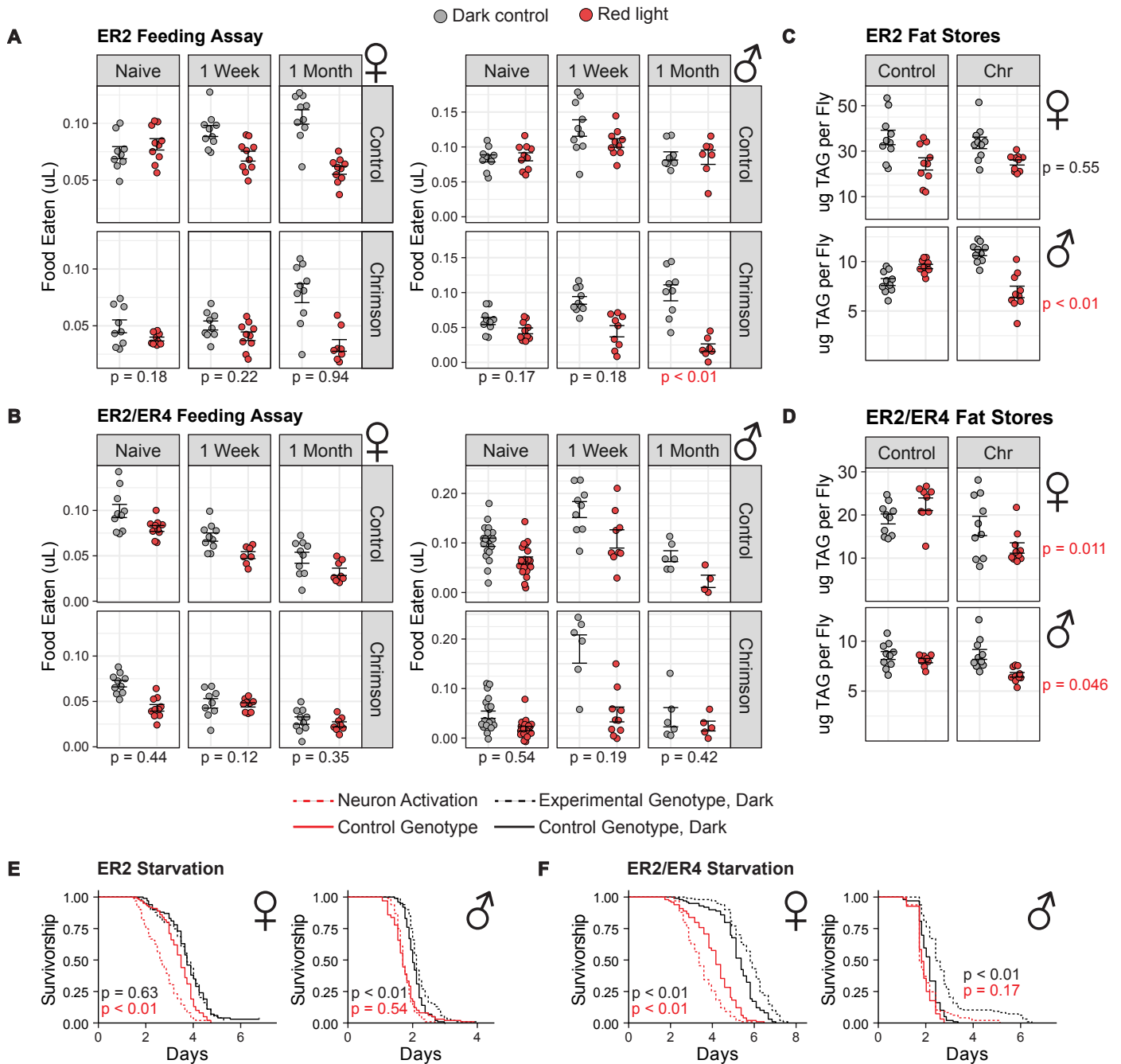


Figure 4. ER2 and ER2/ER4 activation dissociates nutrient-state signaling from behavioral and physiological outputs. (A-D) Interaction (Light $\times$ Genotype) p-values derived from 2-way ANOVAs. Benjamini-Hochberg correction was applied within each sex and driver, and across time points for con-ex. Female TAG points represent 5 flies; all others represent 10 flies. (A) ER2-GAL4 con-ex. ER2-activated females were indistinguishable from controls. Naive and one-week pre-treated males were indistinguishable from controls, but male feeding was reduced after one month of pre-treatment. Female n = 8-10; male n = 7-10. (B) ER2/ER4-GAL4 con-ex. ER2/ER4 activated males and females were indistinguishable from controls at all time points. Female n = 7-10; male n = 18-20 (naïve), 6-10 (1 week), 4-6 (1 month). (C) ER2-GAL4 TAG levels were reduced for males, but not females. n = 10 for both sexes. (D) ER2/ER4-GAL4 TAG levels were reduced for both sexes. Female n = 9-10; male n = 8-10. (E-F) Starvation assays for ER2-GAL4 and ER2/ER4-GAL4 females and males. Flies were pre-treated with light for 1 week before transfer to starvation medium. P-values were obtained by log-rank analysis of correspondingly colored lines. n = 96-100.

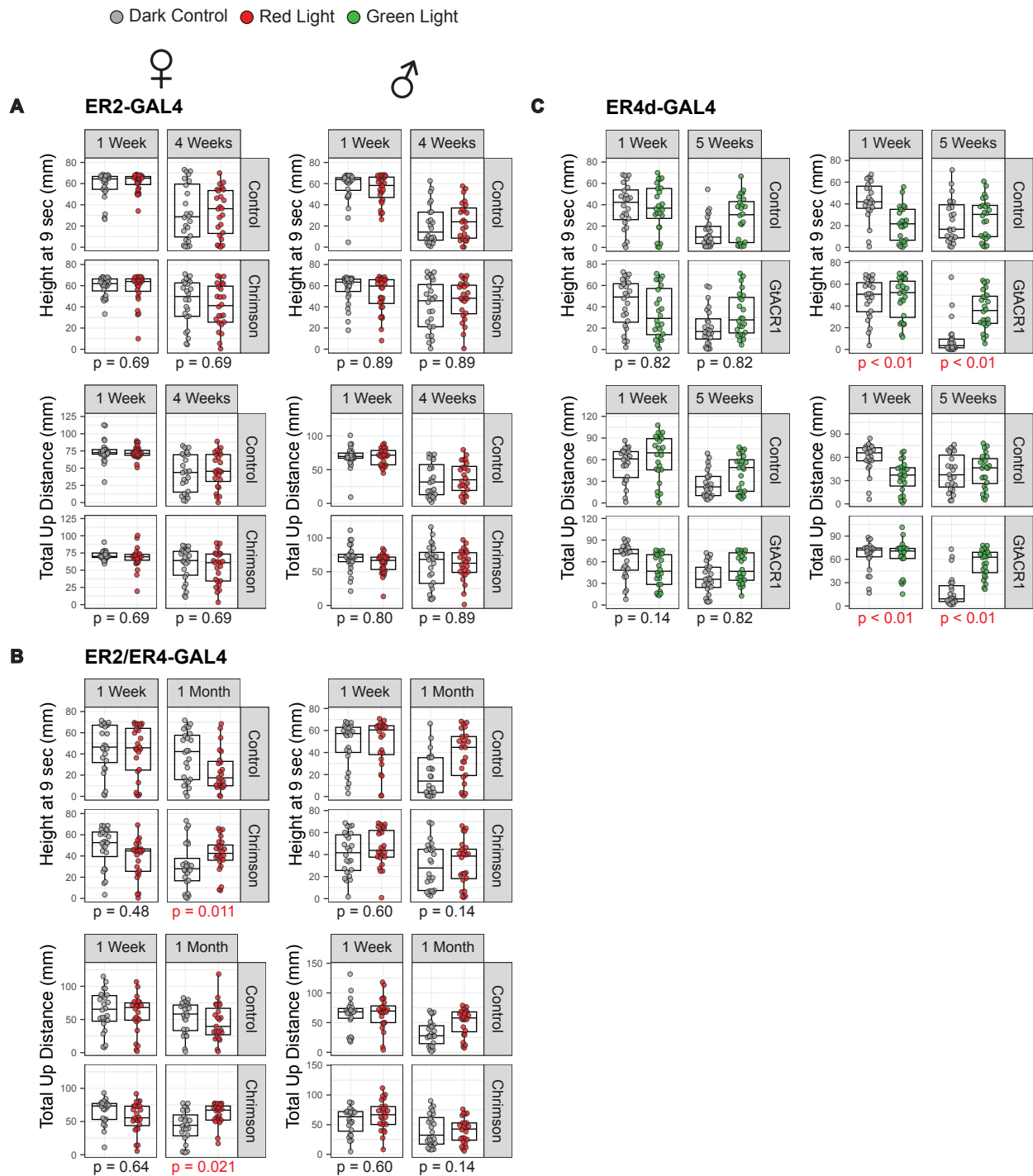


Figure 5. EB manipulation does not impair climbing ability. Height reached by 9 sec after drop (top plots of each panel) and total up distance climbed in 30 sec after drop (bottom plots). Interaction (Light $\times$ Genotype) p-values were derived from 2-way ANOVAs. Benjamini-Hochberg correction was applied within each sex/driver and across time points and climbing metrics. Points represent average of 3 trials per individual. $n = 23-28$. **(A-B)** One week of activation had no effect on ER2 and ER2/ER4 males and females. Female ER2/ER4 flies exhibit improved climbing by both metrics after one month of activation; ER2 females, ER2 males, and ER2/ER4 males exhibit no change after one month. **(C)** ER4d>GtACR1 males, but not females, show improved climbing ability after both one week and five weeks of inhibition.

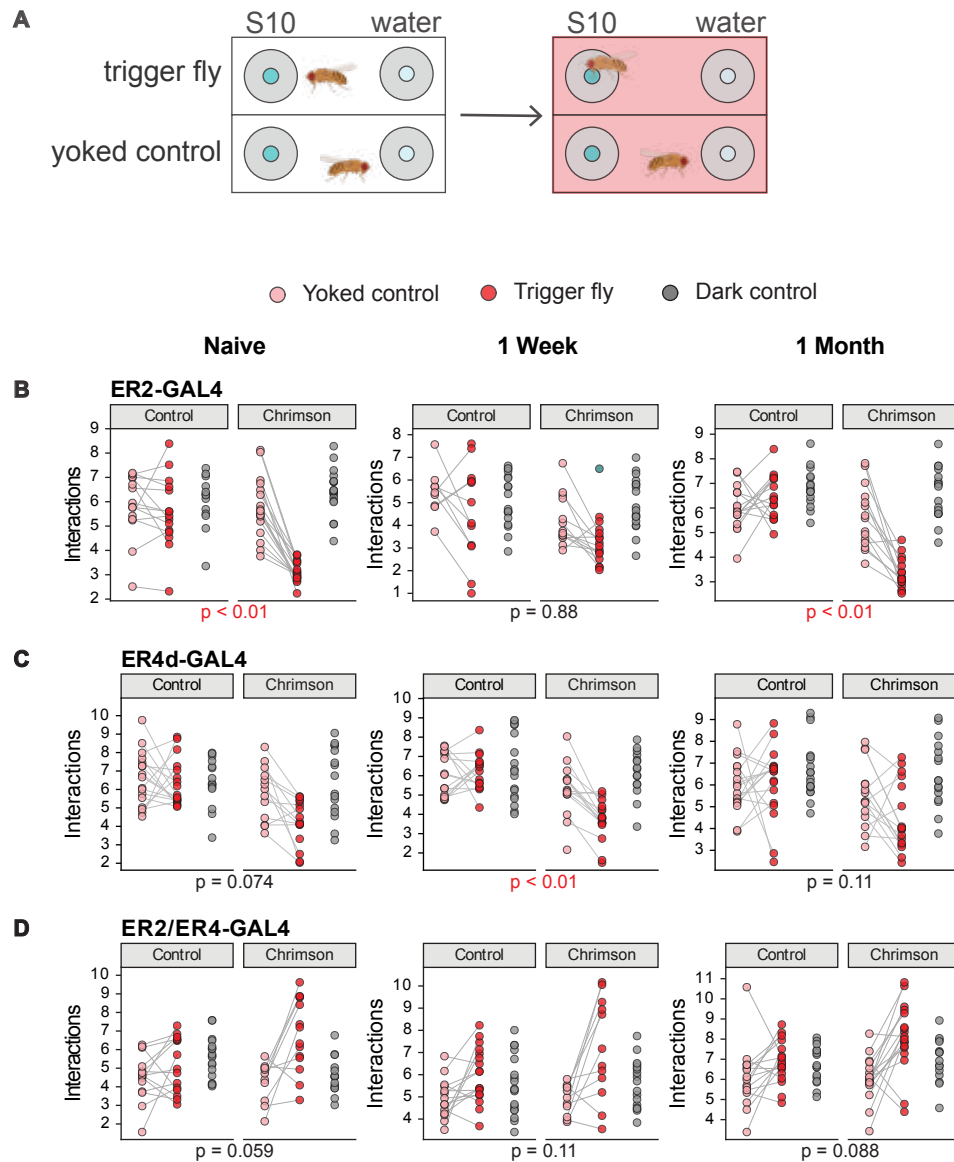


Figure 6. FLIC captures distinct valence states induced by EB manipulation. Female flies were used to assay valence of neuron activation. Sucrose interaction p-values were derived from the Genotype $\times$ Linkage interaction term of a linear mixed model (Interactions ~ Genotype * Linkage + (1|Group), lmer) with yoked pairs modeled as a random intercept. Benjamini-Hochberg correction was applied within each sex and driver and across time points. **(A)** A "trigger" fly (top chamber) controlled optogenetic light for itself and a yoked control (bottom) by touching a 10% sucrose (S10) well. **(B)** ER2 activation was aversive in light-naïve flies and in flies pre-treated with light for 1 month. $n = 9-18$. **(C)** ER4d activation was transiently aversive in flies pre-treated with light for 1 week. $n = 13-18$. **(D)** After correction, ER2/ER4 flies were indistinguishable from yoked controls. Before correction, light-naïve flies found the well rewarding ($p = 0.020$). $n = 10-18$.

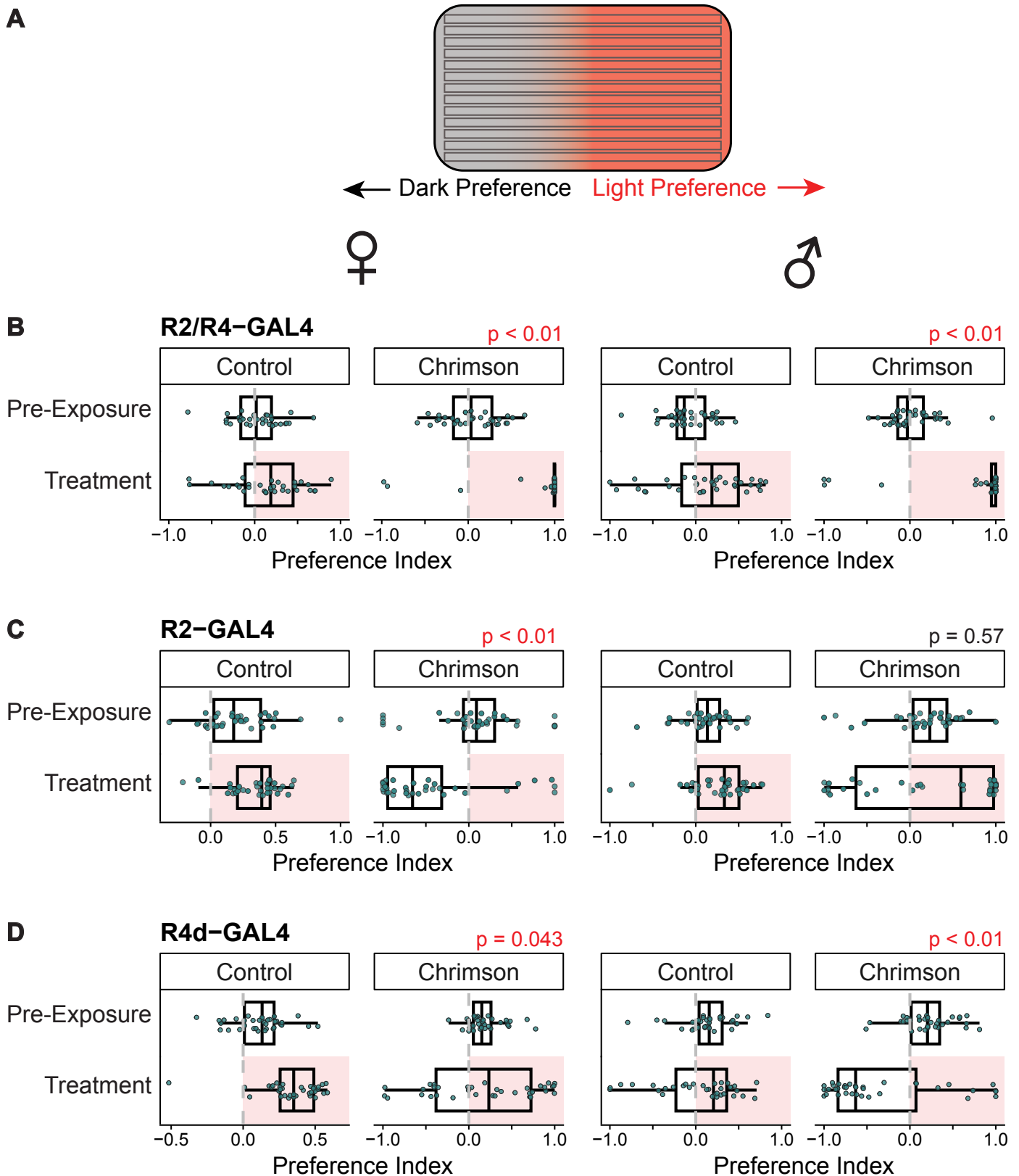


Figure 7. Valence of EB manipulation is sex-, circuit-, and context-dependent. (A) Light-naïve flies ($n = 34-36$) were placed in lanes with a dark side and an illuminated side (red light, 48 Hz) and subjected to a two-phase protocol: 1) a 10-min dark acclimation period; 2) a 60-min treatment of 5 sec on/5 sec off. Reported p-values for Preference Index correspond to Genotype $\times$ Phase interaction term. (B) ER2/ER4>Chr females and males strongly preferred lit side of arena. (C) ER2>Chr females, but not males, preferred dark side. (D) ER4d>Chr females preferred lit side, but showed decreased light preference relative to controls. Males preferred dark side.

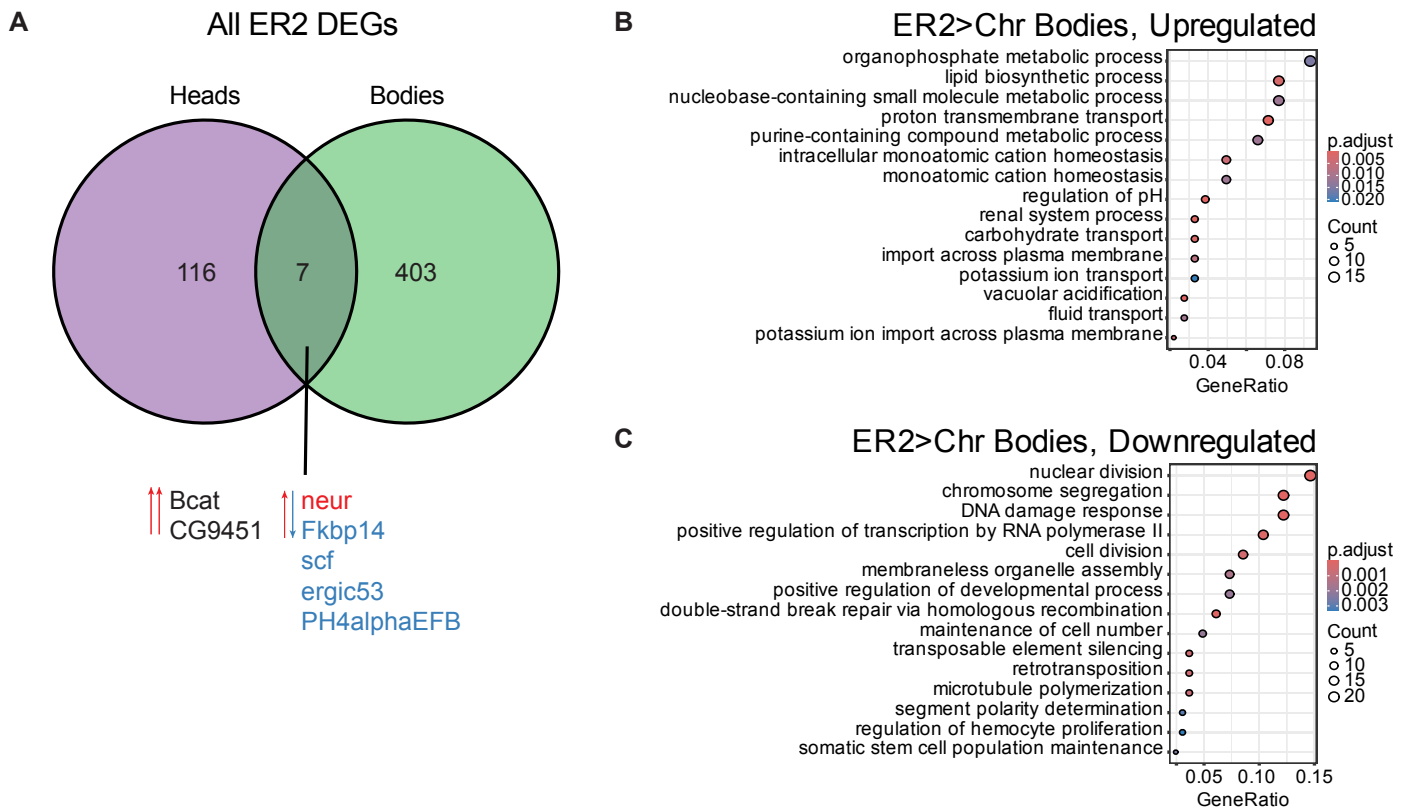


Figure 8. ER2 activation produces transcriptional signatures in the periphery that are distinct from those in the head. Bulk RNA-seq data were acquired from whole bodies of ER2-GAL4 flies treated with light for 1 week. 5 bodies collected per sample. Differentially expressed genes (DEGs) identified at FDR < 0.01 (Benjamini-Hochberg correction) using DESeq2 R package. **(A)** Overlap between all DEGs observed in ER2-activated heads (purple) and bodies (green). Shared genes are indicated by 2 red arrows (upregulated) or a red and blue arrow (oppositely regulated in heads and bodies; red = upregulated in heads, blue = downregulated in heads). **(B)** Top 15 peripheral GO Biological Processes upregulated by ER2 activation. **(C)** Top 15 peripheral GO Biological Processes downregulated by ER2 activation.

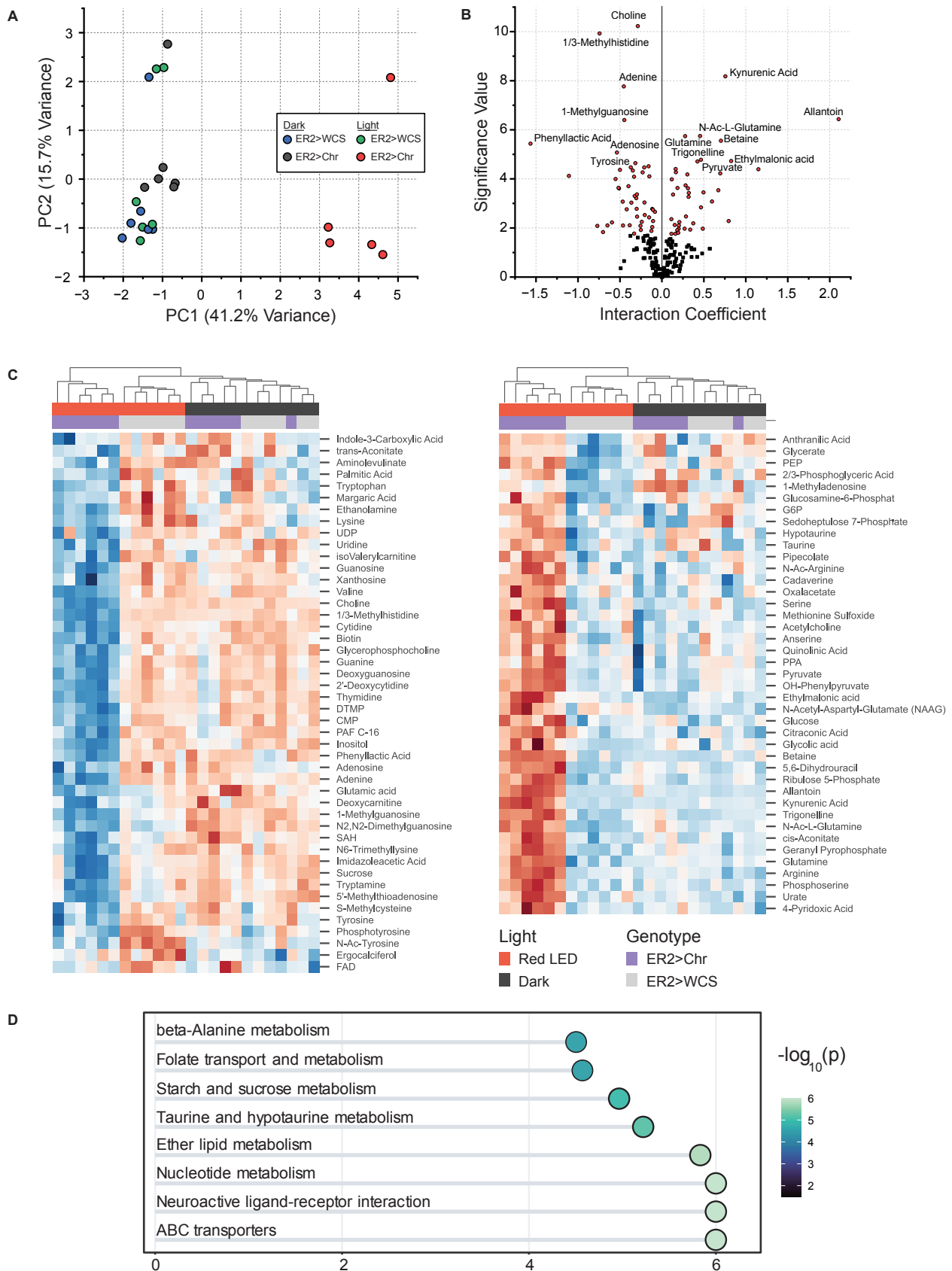


Figure 9. ER2 activation remodels peripheral metabolism. Targeted metabolomic profiling at $FDR < 0.05$ (Light $\times$ Genotype interaction; Benjamini–Hochberg correction). 30 bodies collected per sample. **(A)** PC1 separates ER2-activated flies from all other samples. **(B)** 87 metabolites were significantly affected by EER2 neuron activation (40 up/47 down). **(C)** Peripheral metabolites reduced (left) or increased (right) in abundance upon ER2 activation. Red light treatment separates ER2>Chr flies from all 3 control conditions. **(D)** KEGG pathway enrichment of significantly altered metabolites (FELLA). Dot color and x-axis indicate statistical significance ($-\log_{10}(p)$).

1012 Supplemental Figures

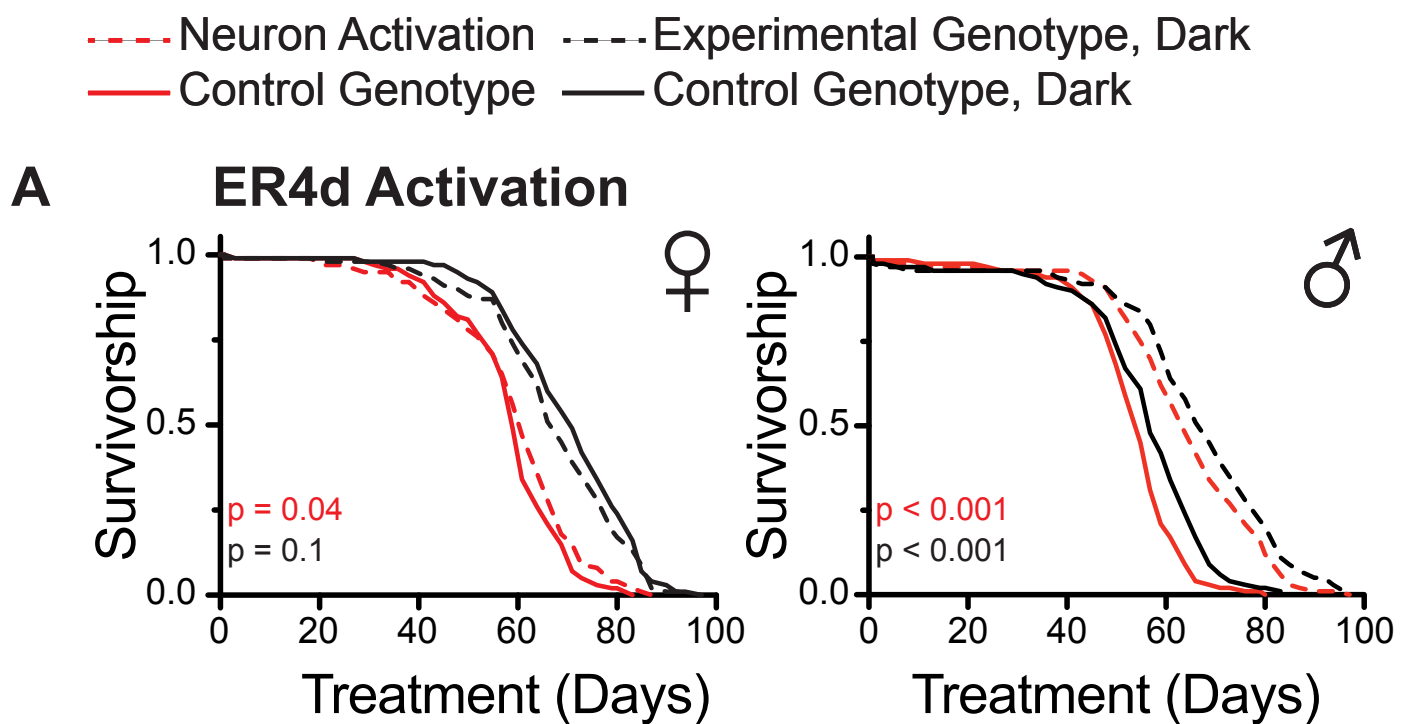


Figure S1. R4d activation modestly extends lifespan in males and females. Flies were mated for two days, then separated by sex and sorted onto all-trans retinal food for 24 hours before optogenetic treatment began. Neurons were activated using UAS-CsChrimson (red lines). Dark controls (black lines) were included for all experiments. P-values were obtained by log-rank analysis of line pairs indicated by color. $n = 180-193$.

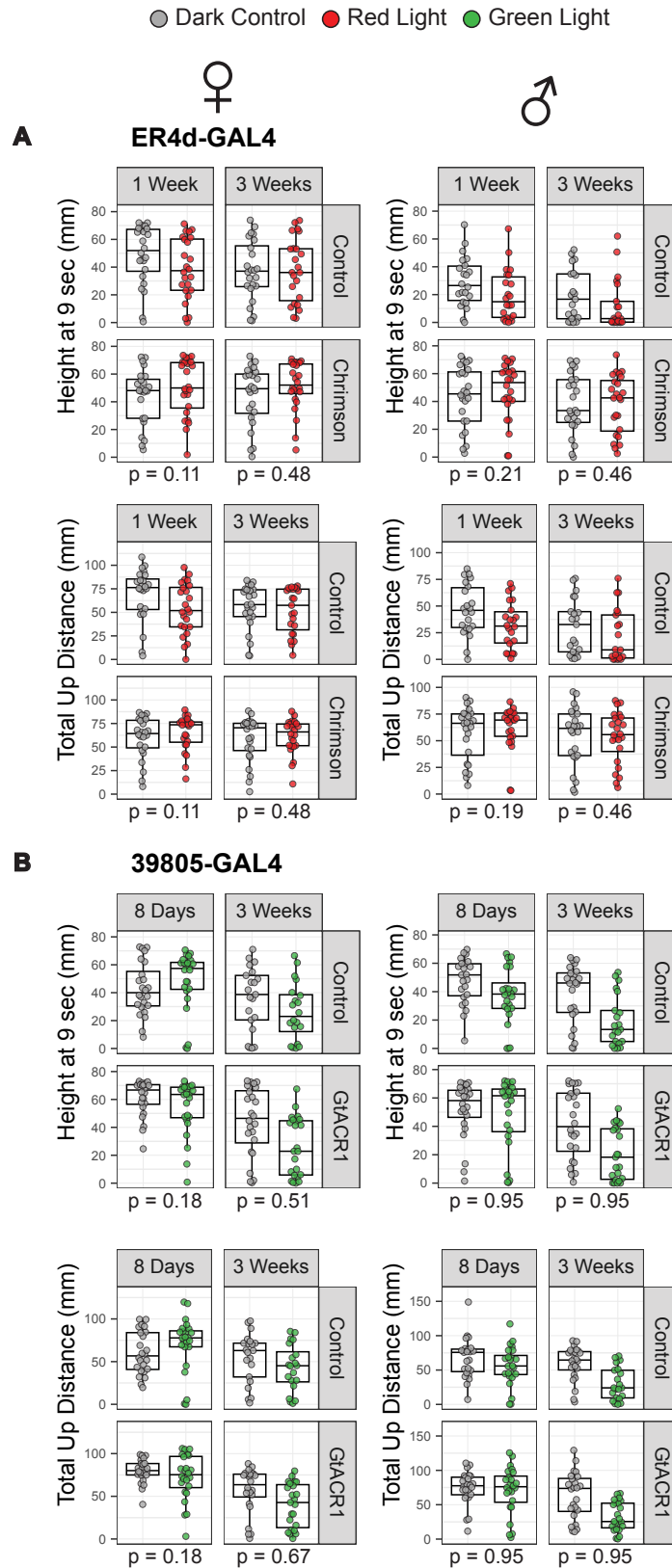


Figure S2. DDrop supplement. Height reached by 9 sec after drop (top plots of each panel) and total up distance climbed in 30 sec after drop (bottom plots). Interaction (Light $\times$ Genotype) p-values were derived from 2-way ANOVAs. Benjamini-Hochberg correction was applied within each sex and driver and across time points and climbing metrics. Points represent average of 3 trials per individual. $n = 20-24$. **(A)** R4d activation has no effect on climbing ability of females or males. **(B)** Broader EB inhibition has no effect on climbing ability of females or males.

○ Yoked control ● Trigger fly ● Dark control

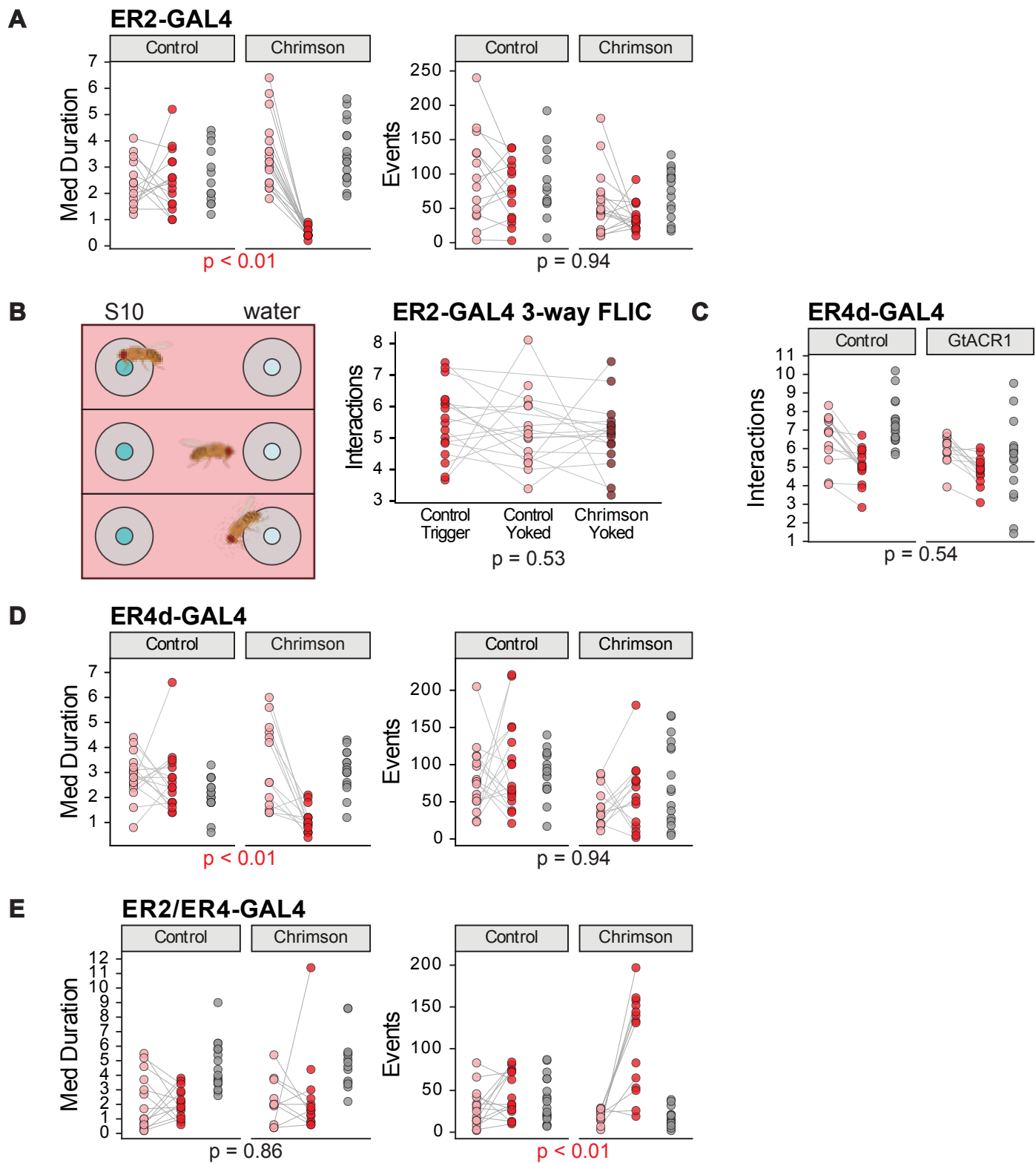


Figure S2. Self-administration of optogenetic activation in FLIC drives nuanced appetitive and aversive behaviors. **(A, C-E)** P-values were derived from the Genotype $\times$ Linkage interaction term of a linear mixed model (Outcome ~ Genotype * Linkage + (1|Group), lmer) with yoked pairs modeled as a random intercept. **(A)** Naive R2>Chr flies spent less time at S10 well per visit (left), but approached it as often as controls (right). n = 13-18. **(B)** (Left) A "trigger" fly (top chamber, R2>WCS) controlled optogenetic light for itself, a yoked genetic control (middle chamber), and a yoked R2>Chr fly (bottom chamber) by touching a 10% sucrose (S10) well. (Right) Naive R2>Chr flies did not interact with well more often than yoked genetic controls, indicating no global, non-associative effects of R2 activation on feeding. P-values were derived from planned contrasts on a linear mixed model (Interactions ~ Condition + (1|Group), lmer) with the yoked pairing structure modeled as a random intercept. n = 16-18. **(C)** Naive R4d>GtACR1 interactions were indistinguishable from controls, as all flies were startled by onset of green light. n = 13-18. **(D)** Naive R4d>Chr trigger flies, like R2 flies, spent less time at the well per visit (left) but returned as frequently as controls (right). n = 13-17. **(E)** R2/R4>Chr trigger flies spent the same amount of time per visit at wells (left) but visited more frequently than controls (right). n = 10-18.

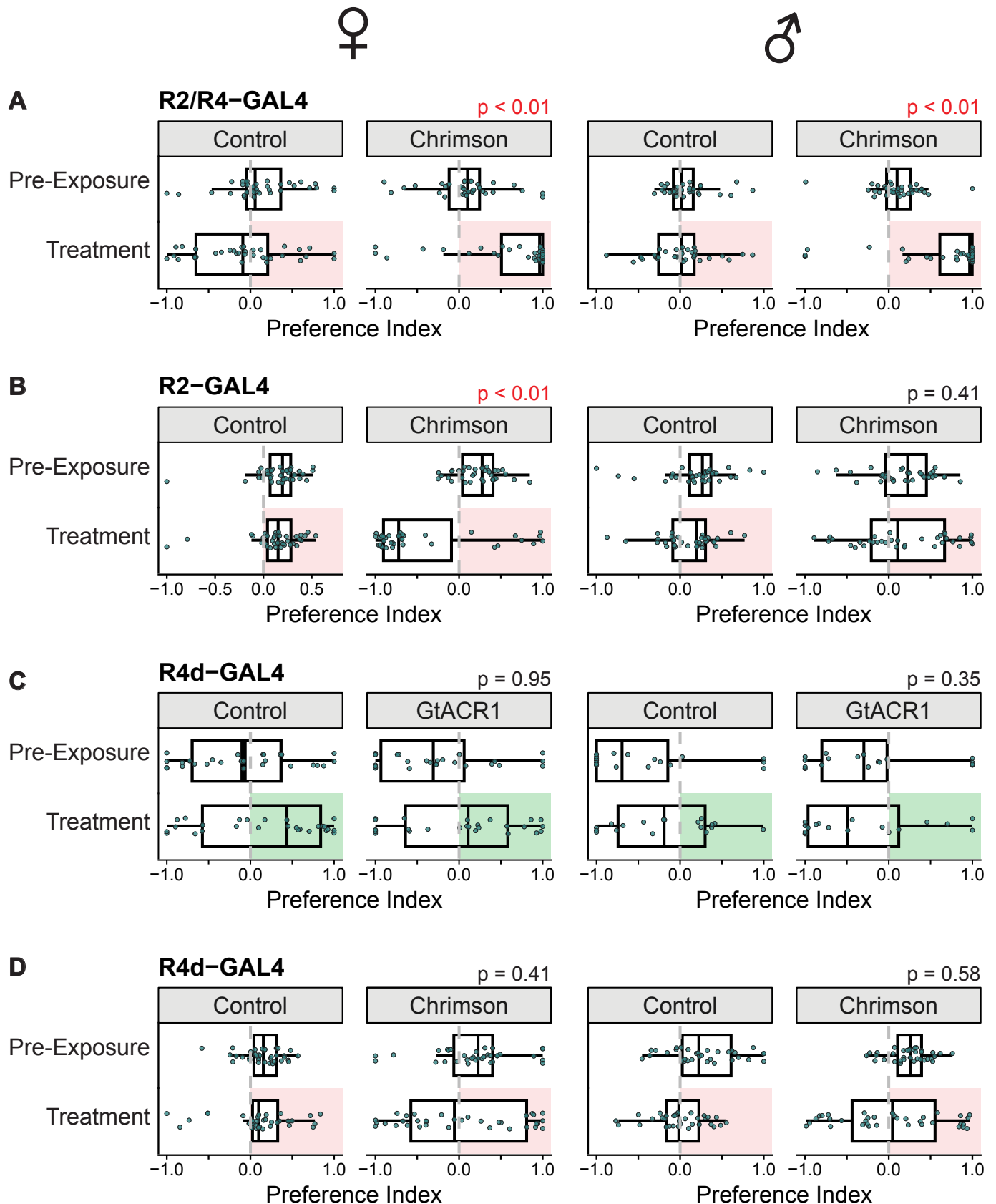


Figure S3. Stimulation frequency modulates EB-driven valence. Light-naïve flies were placed in lanes with a dark side and an illuminated side (red light at 200 Hz or green light at 40 Hz) and subjected to a two-phase protocol: 1) a 10-min dark acclimation period; 2) a 60-min treatment of 5 sec on/5 sec off. Reported p-values for Preference Index correspond to Genotype $\times$ Phase interaction term. **(A)** R2/R4>Chr females and males preferred lit side. $n = 34-36$. **(B)** R2>Chr females preferred unlit side. Males were indistinguishable from controls. $n = 35-36$. **(C)** R4d>GtACR1 females ($n = 26-27$) and males ($n = 17-18$) were indistinguishable from controls. **(D)** R4d>Chr females and males were indistinguishable from controls. $n = 34-36$.

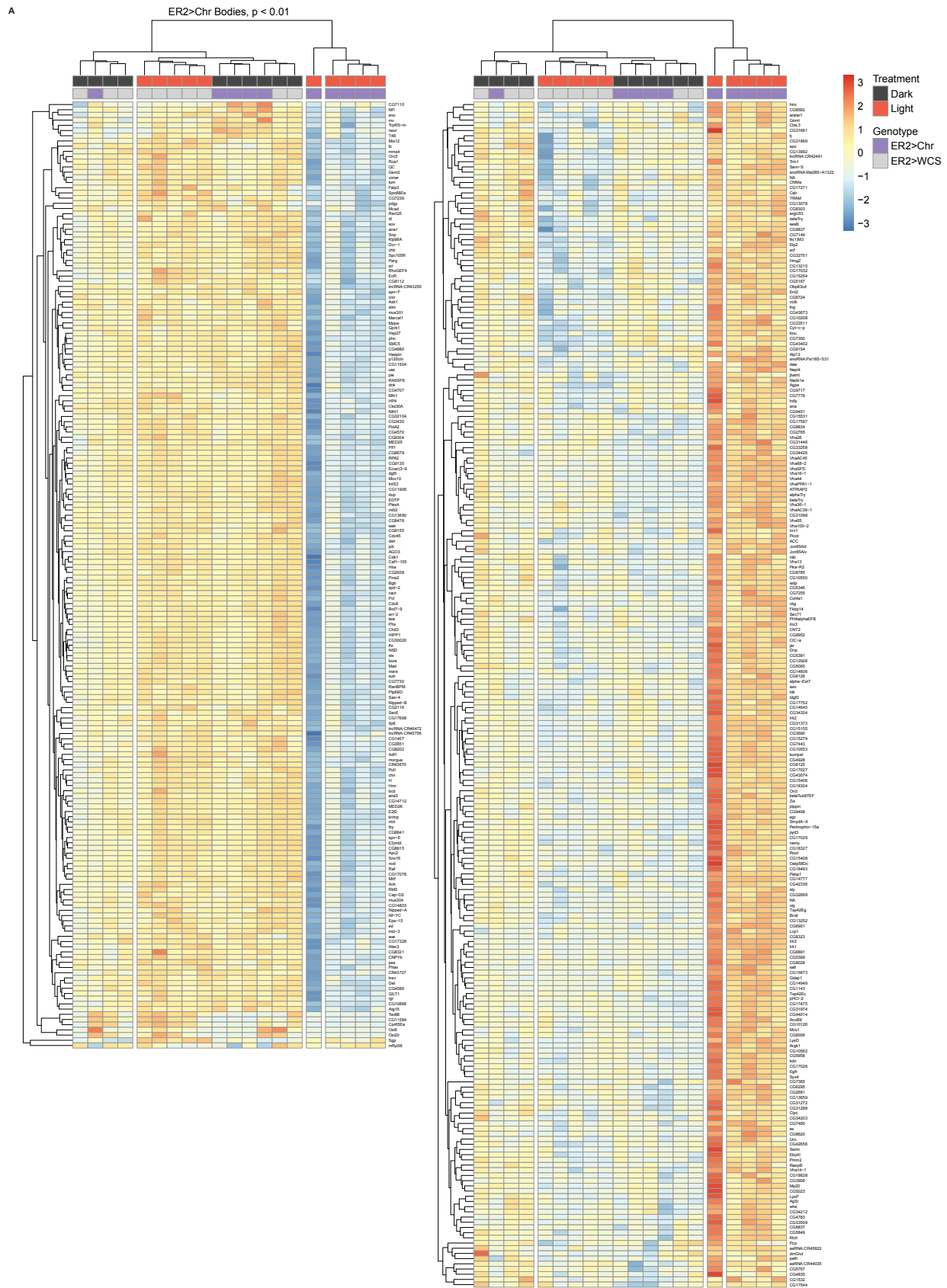


Figure S4. R2 activation drives extensive changes in the peripheral transcriptome. Bulk RNA-seq data from headless bodies of female flies treated with light for 1 week. 5 bodies collected per sample. Differentially expressed genes (DEGs) identified at FDR < 0.01 (Benjamini-Hochberg correction) using DESeq2 R package. **(A)** DEGs downregulated (left) and upregulated (right) by R2 activation (R2>Chr).